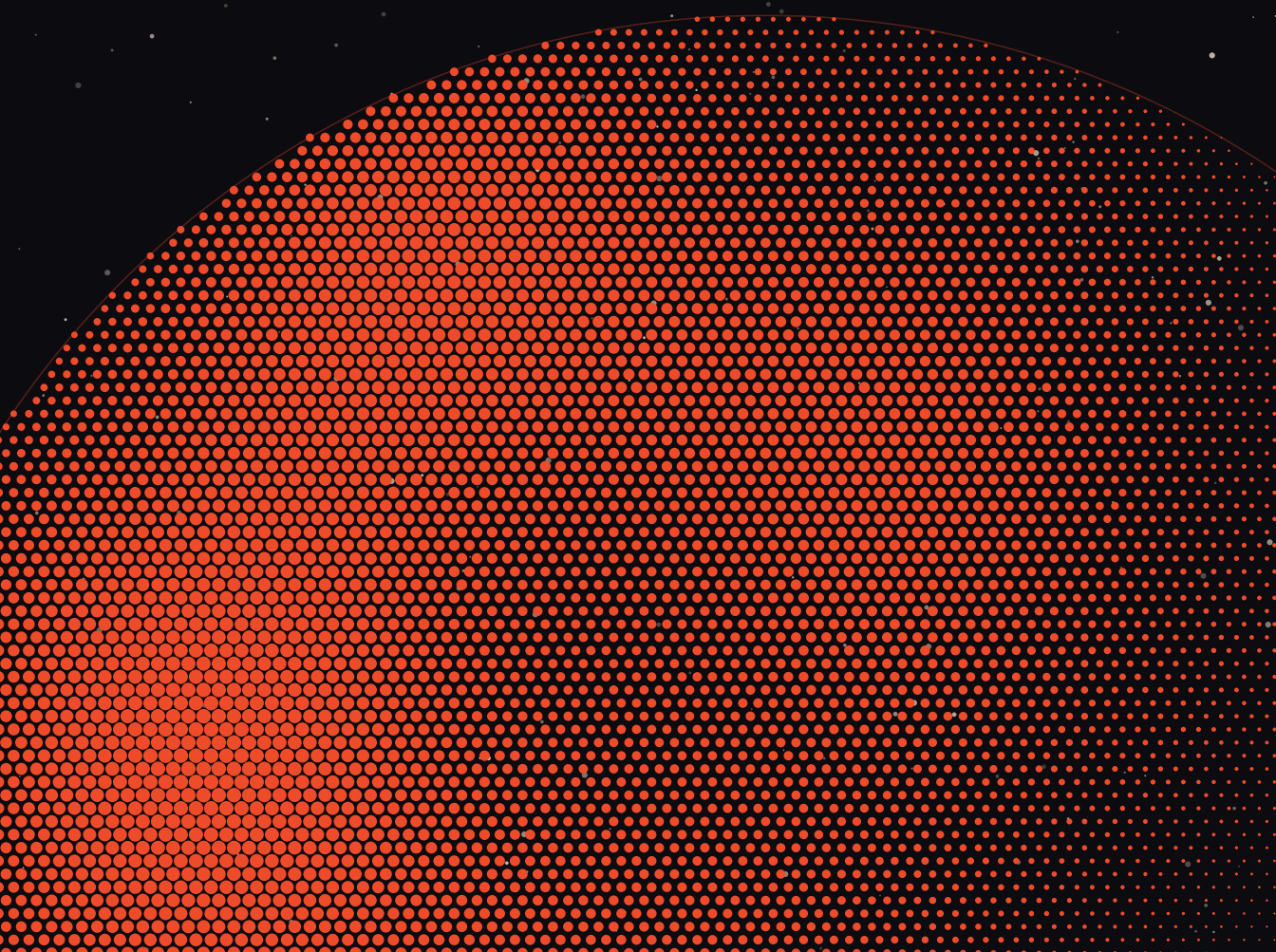
A DOCTORAL THESIS

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CORPUS MARTIANUM

Theophagy, Incorporation, and the Political Theology of Grokking in Robert A. Heinlein's Stranger in a Strange Land



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ABSTRACT

This dissertation contends that Robert A. Heinlein's *Stranger in a Strange Land* (1961; uncut text 1991) is governed, from its neologisms to its eschatology, by a single operation—incorporation—pursued with unusual rigor across five registers: the epistemic, in which to *grok* is literally to drink and understanding is consummated as ingestion; the linguistic, in which acquisition of Martian initiates the speaker into a new ontology; the erotic-communal, in which water-brotherhood and the Nest constitute a body of many members; the juridical-economic, in which a Martian-raised heir is converted into estates, claims, powers of attorney, and finally an incorporated church; and the sacramental-eschatological, in which the protagonist's murdered body is eaten by his disciples and his person promoted into a celestial bureaucracy.

Against the four dominant critical paradigms—countercultural gospel, individualist satire, aesthetic failure, and Menippean restoration—I argue that the novel's notorious contradictions (free love coexisting with summary execution, anti-institutional mysticism culminating in incorporation, radical immanence terminating in an administered Heaven) are not lapses of craft or ideology but the strict consequences of a theology I term *incorporative pantheism*. Its governing law, which I name the *theocorporate conversion*, holds that every democratization of the sacred terminates in its administration: when every Thou is God, divinity must be managed. Extending Kantorowicz, I reconstruct the *three bodies of Valentine Michael Smith*—natural, mystical, and corporate—and read the funeral theophagy as the hinge by which the first is ingested by the second and perpetuated as the third. I further isolate a *witness remainder*—testimony, laughter, and finitude, emblematized by the Fair Witness and by Rodin's *Fallen Caryatid*—which the incorporative system can neither digest nor dispense with, and whose custodian is Jubal Harshaw.

The argument proceeds through three evidentiary registers (attested influence, ambient milieu, structural homology). It reconstructs Heinlein's debts to Kipling, Twain, Cabell, Korzybski, Whorf, the Upanishadic and Transcendentalist traditions, New Thought, Thelema, Frazer, and Freud, and situates the novel among its speculative and philosophical interlocutors: Stapledon, C. S. Lewis, Clarke, Sturgeon, Blish, Miller, Lem, the Strugatsky brothers, Herbert, Vonnegut, Dick, Le Guin, Huxley, Delany, and Chiang. Three subsidiary theses emerge: that American pantheism migrates across the sensorium, from Emerson's eye through Whitman's touch to Heinlein's mouth; that 1961—the year of *Solaris*, *Totality and Infinity*, *Histoire de la folie*, and *Asylums*—constitutes an *annus mirabilis* of alterity to which Heinlein's novel furnishes the incorporative answer; and that the novel is formally a *Menippean gospel*, a scripture that contains the satire of its own apotheosis. A coda traces the migration of *grok* into hacker culture, machine-learning theory, and corporate artificial-intelligence branding, and argues that this afterlife completes the theocorporate conversion the novel foretold.

00

THE STRANGER'S BODY

A Book More Eaten Than Read

Few novels have been so thoroughly consumed by their readers as *Stranger in a Strange Land*. Within months of its publication a water-brotherhood formed on its model among undergraduates at Westminster College in Fulton, Missouri; by 1968 that brotherhood had been incorporated as the Church of All Worlds, a legally constituted neopagan body whose liturgy adapted the novel's creed. Within a decade the book's vocabulary circulated through the communal and psychedelic subcultures, and the press, on evidence that Heinlein and his biographer contested, associated it with the Manson "Family," whose leader had given one of his sons the name Valentine Michael. Members of that group, acting at Charles Manson's direction, murdered seven people in Los Angeles over two nights in August 1969, among them the actress Sharon Tate; Manson and the four followers who carried out the killings, Charles Watson, Susan Atkins, Patricia Krenwinkel, and Leslie Van Houten, were convicted of murder in 1971. Within two decades *grok* had entered the hacker lexicon and, soon after, the *Oxford English Dictionary*;

within six it had become a term of art in machine-learning research and the trademark of a commercial conversational system. The novel has, in short, been ingested—assimilated into bodies, institutions, and idioms that metabolized its content while excreting its form.

This reception history is not incidental to the text. It is the text's own thesis, executed upon it. A novel whose central verb means "to drink," whose central sacrament is the sharing of water, and whose climactic rite is the eating of its hero has been drunk and eaten, and the manner of its consumption is continuous with the logic it articulates. The present study takes that continuity as its point of departure. It asks what theory of knowledge, divinity, community, law, and death would make the eating of a messiah the natural culmination of a narrative, and it answers that the novel is organized, at every level, by a single operation whose semantic range the English word *incorporation* uniquely spans.

> *The novel has, in short, been ingested—assimilated into bodies, institutions, and idioms that metabolized its content while excreting its form.*

II

The State of the Question

Criticism of the novel has crystallized around four paradigms, each of which purchases coherence by discounting half the text. The first, the *countercultural gospel*, reads the book as scripture: a charter for communal eros, psychic self-mastery, and post-Christian religiosity. It possesses the authority of reception but founders on the novel's satire of its own heaven and on Heinlein's persistent disavowals; in later correspondence he characterized the book as an interrogation of the sexual and religious axioms of Western culture and insisted that it posed questions rather than supplied answers. The second paradigm, the *individualist satire*, privileges Jubal Harshaw's corrosive voice and reads the mysticism as metaphor—a parable of self-reliance dressed in Martian costume. It accounts for the lampoons of the World Federation and the

Fosterite church but cannot account for the narrative's evident investment in the Nest, whose miracles the novel never ironizes.

The third paradigm, the *aesthetic-failure thesis*, pressed early by Alexei Panshin (1968) and repeated since, holds that the second half collapses narrative into homily and that the novel's contradictions are symptoms of an author who could no longer discipline his convictions. The fourth, the *Menippean restoration*, most fully developed in William H. Patterson Jr. and Andrew Thornton's *The Martian Named Smith* (2001), relocates the book within the satiric lineage that runs from Lucian through Rabelais and Swift to James Branch Cabell, and so recovers its generic intelligence. Adjacent to these stand George Slusser's reading of Heinlein's fiction as a secularized Calvinism of the elect (1976), H. Bruce Franklin's historicist placement of the author within the contradictions of postwar American liberalism (1980), and Farah Mendlesohn's comprehensive reassessment (2019). The Menippean paradigm is the most sophisticated of the four, but it describes a genre without explaining what the genre is *for*: it tells us that the novel mixes the sacred and the profane, the heavenly and the carnivalesque, without telling us why a creed of radical immanence should require a satirical bureaucracy of angels to complete it. The present study supplies that explanation.

III

The Textual Body

The novel exists in two bodies. Gestated across more than a decade—from Virginia Heinlein's late-1940s suggestion of a Mowgli raised by Martians to its completion in 1960—the manuscript was reduced by roughly a quarter before publication at the publisher's insistence, and the longer text appeared only in 1991, three years after the author's death, under his widow's supervision. The excision is itself an incorporation: the digestion of an unassimilable manuscript by a commercial firm, which returned to the public a text shorn of much of its sexual and theological candor. This study treats the 1961 text as the historically operative body, since it is the one the counterculture ingested, and the 1991 text as the authorially intended one, noting divergence where it bears on the argument. Because the novel remains in copyright, it is cited here by part and episode and rendered in paraphrase; its coinages—*grok*, *discorporate*, *water brother*, *waiting is*, *Thou art God*—are treated as the philosophemes they are.

The architecture of both texts is itself an argument. Its five parts—"His Maculate Origin," "His Preposterous Heritage," "His Eccentric Education," "His Scandalous Career," and "His Happy Destiny"—parody the structure of the saint's *vita* and, in the first title, invert the Immaculate Conception into the frank record of an adulterous conception aboard the first Martian expedition. The novel announces from its table of contents that it will narrate a life of Christ in which every sacred category is reproduced in a stained, legal, commercial, and corporeal key.

IV

Thesis

Incorporation designates, in at least five idioms, the admission of something into a body: in the alimentary idiom, ingestion; in the social idiom, admission to membership; in the juridical idiom, the constitution of a corporation, a *persona ficta* that outlives its members; in the theological idiom, entry into the *corpus mysticum*, the body of Christ constituted by the Eucharist; and in the psychoanalytic idiom, the fantasmatic swallowing of a lost object. *Stranger in a Strange Land* mobilizes all five, and it is the novel's singular achievement to make them converge upon a single event—the eating of Valentine Michael Smith by the community he founded—which is simultaneously an act of knowledge, a sacrament, a succession, an endowment, and a work of mourning.

From this convergence I derive the dissertation's five theses. First, the novel articulates a theology I term *incorporative pantheism*, in which divinity is realized neither by transcendence nor by immanence as such but by the progressive, reversible ingestion of others into a shared body. Second, that theology obeys a law I call the *theocorporate conversion:* every democratization of the sacred terminates in its incorporation and administration, so that the more widely divinity is distributed, the more elaborately it must be managed. Third, the protagonist possesses not two bodies, as in Kantorowicz's medieval king, but three—natural, mystical, and corporate—and the plot is the transfer of his person from the first to the third through the second. Fourth, the incorporative system generates a *witness remainder*—testimony, laughter, and finitude—that it requires and cannot metabolize. Fifth, the form proper to such a theology is the *Menippean gospel*, a scripture that must satirize its own apotheosis in order to remain credible.

V

Method

The study distinguishes three evidentiary registers and marks them throughout. The *attested* register comprises sources Heinlein demonstrably read, cited, or acknowledged: Kipling, Twain, Cabell, Rodin, the King James Bible, and Alfred Korzybski, whose General Semantics he publicly championed. The *ambient* register comprises sources present in his documented milieu whose direct influence cannot be proven but whose atmosphere he breathed: the metaphysical, Vedantic, and Thelemic subcultures of 1940s Los Angeles; American New Thought; Frazerian anthropology; and popular Freudianism. The *homologous* register comprises structures shared with thinkers Heinlein did not read and in several cases could not have read, including Levinas, Girard, Agamben, Abraham and Torok, and Viveiros de Castro, whose relevance is structural rather than genetic. Conflating these registers has vitiated much source criticism of the novel; keeping them distinct allows bold comparison without false genealogy.

Three methods operate within these registers. *Speculative philology* reads the novel's coinages as compressed philosophical arguments whose etymology, grammar, and semantic field disclose commitments the narrative never states. *Political theology*, in the line of Carl Schmitt, Ernst Kantorowicz, Henri de Lubac, and Giorgio Agamben, supplies the vocabulary for the novel's fusion of sovereignty, sacrament, and corporation. *Comparative novum analysis*, adapted from Darko Suvin, reads the novel's central speculative premise against those of cognate works in order to specify what is singular in Heinlein's solution.

VI

Corpus Martianum

The title condenses the argument. *Corpus mysticum* named, successively, the Eucharistic host, the Church, and the realm; *corpus Martianum* names the Martian body into which the novel's humanity is to be incorporated. *Corpus* also names a body of texts, and the coda will argue that the novel's epistemology of ingestion has found its most literal contemporary realization in machines trained upon a textual corpus. A single Latin noun thus spans the eaten god, the founded church, the legal person, and the ingested archive.

VII

Architecture of the Argument

Part One (Chapters One and Two) reconstructs genealogies: the stranger's provenance in Exodus, Kipling, the Enlightenment *ingénu*, Twain, and Gnosticism, and the Martian language's provenance in General Semantics and linguistic relativity. Part Two (Chapters Three to Five) analyzes doctrine: the alimentary epistemology of *grok*, the second-person theology of *Thou art God*, and the hydraulic kinship and communal eros of the Nest. Part Three (Chapters Six and Seven) analyzes institutions: the corporate sacred of the Fosterites, the Church of All Worlds, and Heaven, and the political theology of sovereignty and discorporation. Part Four (Chapters Eight and Nine) analyzes ends: the fall into laughter and the ethics of finitude, and the theophagy that founds the body. Chapter Ten formalizes the theory, and a coda follows *grok* into the age of machine learning.

PART ONE

I

GENEALOGIES

The stranger's provenance in Exodus, Kipling, the Enlightenment ingénu, *Twain, and Gnosticism, and the Martian language's provenance in General Semantics and linguistic relativity.*

01 The Stranger's Provenance 11

02 The Semantics of Salvation 16



01

THE STRANGER'S PROVENANCE

Mowgli, Moses, the Ingénu, and the Alien God

The novel's protagonist is assembled from four inherited figures—the fugitive lawgiver, the feral heir, the estranging visitor, and the Gnostic messenger—and his singularity lies in the way Heinlein fuses their incompatible destinies into one. Each inheritance contributes a function: the lawgiver founds a people, the feral child tests the boundary of the human, the visitor exposes the arbitrariness of custom, and the messenger redeems an elect. Only in their fusion does the stranger become edible.

1.1

Gershom's Name

The title is taken from Exodus 2:22, where Moses, exiled in Midian, names his son Gershom, "for he said, I have been a stranger in a strange land." The Hebrew folk etymology joins *ger*, the resident alien, to *sham*, "there": the child's name is a memorial of displacement. The context sharpens the allusion. Moses is in Midian because he has killed an Egyptian overseer and fled the consequences (Exodus 2:11–15); the future lawgiver of Israel is first a homicide beyond the reach of law. Alien, killer, and founder are one person before they

are three offices. Heinlein transposes the configuration wholesale: his stranger will kill without trial, found a people, and legislate a new relation to the divine.

Freud's *Moses and Monotheism* (1939) radicalizes the inheritance. Freud's Moses is an Egyptian—a stranger to the very people he constitutes—who imposes an austere monotheism and is murdered by his followers; the religion survives because the murder is repressed and returns as guilt. Valentine Michael Smith is likewise a stranger to the species he founds anew, and likewise murdered by it, but in Heinlein the religion returns not as repressed guilt but as ingested joy. A third biblical text completes the triad. Hebrews 13:2 counsels hospitality because "some have entertained angels unawares," and the novel's coda literalizes the counsel: the stranger Earth failed to entertain was the archangel Michael. Estrangement, homicidal legislation, and angelic incognito are thus encoded in the title before the first chapter begins.

1.2

Mowgli and the Heir: The Feral Child as Political Problem

The attested germ of the novel is Virginia Heinlein's proposal of a Mowgli raised by Martians rather than wolves. Kipling's *Jungle Books* (1894–95) supply more than a premise. Mowgli lives between two legal orders, the Law of the Jungle and the custom of the village, and belongs fully to neither; and in "Tiger! Tiger!" the villagers, persuaded that the wolf-child is a sorcerer, drive him out under a hail of stones. The feral child's destiny is expulsion by stoning, and Heinlein's stranger will die the same way.

> *Heinlein's American answer is that the Other is to be drunk.*

The Enlightenment made the feral child an experimental subject—Rousseau's *Émile* (1762), Itard's reports on Victor of Aveyron (1801, 1806)—but the nineteenth century made him a political one. Kaspar Hauser, who appeared in Nuremberg in 1828 raised in near-total isolation, became a European sensation, was rumored to be the dispossessed hereditary prince of Baden, and died in December 1833 of a stab wound inflicted in a park in Ansbach by an assailant who was never identified. Hauser is Mike's closest historical type: a youth

reared outside human society who arrives unable to communicate, is exhibited, medicalized, and speculated upon, is suspected of being a displaced sovereign, and dies by violence. An emblematic convergence deserves record, though it proves nothing genetic. Hauser's guardian and chronicler was the jurist Anselm von Feuerbach, whose 1832 account made the case famous; Anselm's son was Ludwig Feuerbach, whose formula *homo homini Deus est* anticipates the creed of *Thou art God*. The genealogy of the stranger and the genealogy of the human god share a household.

Heinlein adds the decisive modern element: property. Mike is heir, through his mother's patents and the mutual contracts of the lost expedition's crew, to an immense fortune, and under the novel's fictional Larkin Decision he is a potential claimant to sovereignty over Mars. The feral child is no longer merely a philosophical test of human nature; he is a legal and financial event, a body to which claims, estates, and jurisdictions adhere. This is the first sign that the stranger's natural body will be shadowed by a corporate one.

1.3

The Ingénu and the Estranging Eye

The eighteenth century perfected the device of the foreign observer whose incomprehension exposes the arbitrariness of domestic custom: Montesquieu's *Persian Letters* (1721), Voltaire's *Micromégas* (1752)—whose visitor from Sirius is arguably the first extraterrestrial satirist—and *L'Ingénu* (1767), Swift's Houyhnhnms (1726), and Goldsmith's *Citizen of the World* (1760–61). Mark Twain, Heinlein's acknowledged master, gave the device its most corrosive modern form in *The Mysterious Stranger* (1916), whose angelic visitor despises the human "moral sense," declares that "against the assault of laughter nothing can stand," and ends by informing his human companion that the universe is a dream and he a solitary, vagrant thought. Heinlein inherits both halves of Twain's bequest: the doctrine of laughter as humanity's saving weapon (Chapter Eight) and the metaphysical solipsism that his later fiction would elaborate (Chapter Four).

Viktor Shklovsky's "Art as Device" (1917) theorized the operation as *ostranenie*, estrangement, taking Tolstoy's "Kholstomer," in which a horse fails to comprehend private property, as a paradigm. Mike's early incomprehension of clothing, money, jealousy, idiom, and death is Kholstomer's incomprehension of ownership extended to the whole of human custom. Darko

Suvin (1979) later defined science fiction itself as the literature of *cognitive estrangement*, organized around a *novum*. Heinlein's innovation is to make the device a character and then to make the character a prophet. The classical *ingénu* observes and returns home to report; Mike stays and founds. Estrangement is converted into apostolate. And the estranging eye is not stable: Mike is progressively absorbed into what he observes, learning to laugh, love, and dissemble. The observer becomes part of the observed—which is to say that the estranging device obeys the very definition of *grok* that the novel will propose.

1.4

The Alien God: Gnostic Structures

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958), published three years before the novel, identified "the alien" as the primal symbol of Gnosticism: the true God is foreign to the cosmos, the soul is a stranger imprisoned in it, and the redeemer descends as a stranger bearing a call. The Hymn of the Pearl in the *Acts of Thomas* narrates the pattern: a prince sent from the East into Egypt to retrieve a pearl eats the Egyptians' food, forgets his mission, is awakened by a letter, seizes the pearl, and returns to his celestial robe. Mike's itinerary inverts and completes it. Sent from the red planet as an heir, he does not forget his origin; he must instead learn the Egyptians' forgetting—laughter, money, sexual jealousy—in order to redeem them, and he returns at last to a Pleroma rendered as an office.

The Gnostic apparatus is extensive. *Gnosis* is knowledge that transforms the knower into the known, which is the formal definition of *grok*; the Nest corresponds to the pneumatic elect, the Fosterite church to the psychic multitude, and the World Federation to the archons who govern the lower world. Eric Voegelin's *New Science of Politics* (1952) had already diagnosed modern mass movements as Gnostic attempts to immanentize the eschaton, and Slusser's Calvinist reading of Heinlein's elect belongs to the same family. Yet the Gnostic frame fails at the decisive point. Gnosticism despises matter and the body; Heinlein's gnosis is carnal, attained through water, sexual union, and finally the eating of flesh. The novel is a Gnosticism of the mouth—an incarnational gnosis—and that paradox, knowledge of the spirit achieved by ingestion of the body, is the seed from which this dissertation's thesis grows.

1.5

1961: An Annus Mirabilis of Alterity

The year of publication was saturated with strangers. On 12 April Yuri Gagarin became the first human to leave the Earth and return, an inverse Mike; in January Eisenhower's farewell address warned of a military-industrial complex; in August the Berlin Wall divided a city into mutual aliens; in October the Soviet Union detonated the largest weapon ever tested, placing a power of planetary annihilation, which the novel ascribes to Martian elders, in human hands. Joseph Heller's *Catch-22* satirized a war-profiteering syndicate in which everyone holds a share—incorporation as universal complicity.

The philosophical and speculative harvest of 1961 converged on the problem of the Other. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* presented an alien intelligence that cannot be understood and returns to its observers only mirrors of themselves. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* grounded ethics in the irreducibility of the Other and analyzed nourishment as the assimilation of the other into the same. Michel Foucault's *Histoire de la folie* traced the confinement of unreason; Erving Goffman's *Asylums* anatomized the total institution, which is where Heinlein's stranger begins, held incommunicado in a hospital. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's "Eye and Mind" theorized the reversibility of seer and seen. The European works of 1961 insist, in different idioms, that the Other resists assimilation—by confinement, by representation, by understanding. Heinlein's American answer is that the Other is to be drunk. *Stranger in a Strange Land* is the incorporative pole of the great argument over alterity conducted in 1961, and *Solaris* and *Totality and Infinity* are its non-incorporative antipodes.

02

THE SEMANTICS OF SALVATION

General Semantics, Linguistic Relativity, and the Martian Tongue

Heinlein's Martian is the most soteriological invented language in the speculative canon: its acquisition confers not merely new concepts but new powers and, finally, membership in a church. It is also a language at war with the linguistic philosophy that inspired it. The novel borrows from Alfred Korzybski the conviction that language shapes sanity and then uses that conviction to overturn Korzybski's central prohibition.

2.1

Korzybski's Apostle

Korzybski's *Science and Sanity* (1933) proposed a "non-Aristotelian" discipline, General Semantics, grounded in the maxim that the map is not the territory. Its practical program targeted the verb *to be*: the "is of identity" ("John is a fool") and the "is of predication" ("the leaf is green") were diagnosed as sources of semantic disturbance that confuse levels of abstraction. The remedies were extensional devices—indexing (chair_1, chair_2), dating (Smith_{1950}, Smith_{1960}), the habitual "etc."—and the ideal was a mind that remains conscious of its own abstracting. In *Manhood of Humanity* (1921) Korzybski had defined the species

by "time-binding," its capacity to transmit accumulated knowledge across generations.

Heinlein's commitment is attested. In his Guest of Honor address at the 1941 World Science Fiction Convention in Denver he urged his audience toward Korzybski, and his 1949 novella "Gulf" imagined a secret society of superior humans who think in Speedtalk, an engineered language of maximal compression and precision. The Fair Witness in *Stranger in a Strange Land* is Korzybski's saint institutionalized: a licensed professional trained to perceive without inference and to testify without extrapolation, whose statements the law treats as conclusive precisely because they never exceed their evidence. Anne, Jubal's secretary and a certified Witness, will not assert the color of a house beyond the side she can see. Her profession is an extensional device made into a civic office: indexing and dating incarnate.

2.2

Whorf's Martian

Benjamin Lee Whorf's essays of 1939–1941, collected in *Language, Thought, and Reality* (1956), argued that grammatical structure conditions habitual cognition, and his analysis of Hopi temporality became the emblem of linguistic relativity. Heinlein's Martian adopts the strongest version of the hypothesis available to fiction. Martian is not a code for concepts English already possesses; it is a cognitive and somatic technology. Mike repeatedly insists that essential ideas cannot be carried into English without loss, and his church's pedagogy is, at its core, language instruction: those who master Martian acquire bodily self-regulation, perception of others' minds, and the capacity to act upon matter. Salvation is by grammar.

> *Salvation is by grammar.*

It is apt that the first human scholar of Martian in the novel is the semanticist Mahmoud, a devout Muslim from the second expedition. His tradition holds that the Qur'an is inimitable (*iʿjāz al-Qurʾān*) and that its liturgical force does not survive translation; he thus comes to Martian already formed by a theology of the untranslatable revealed tongue. Heinlein, whether by design or by the

logic of his premise, gives the Martian language its first human reader in a man prepared to believe that a grammar can be a vessel of revelation.

2.3

The Korzybskian Heresy

Here the novel turns against its master. General Semantics warns above all against the "is of identity," and *Thou art God* is that locution raised to its maximal power: an identity statement joining the most concrete of addressees to the most abstract of predicates. *Grok*, which the novel glosses as understanding so complete that the knower merges with the known, abolishes the map-territory distinction altogether; the grokker does not represent the territory but becomes it. David Bourland's E-Prime (1965), an English purged of every form of *to be*, would render the church's creed unsayable. The Martian creed is a Korzybskian heresy.

The novel stages this heresy as a drama between persons. Anne embodies the map that knows it is not the territory; Mike embodies the map that has become the territory and the mapper at once. Mike begins as a hyper-extensional literalist—confounded by idiom and polysemy, unable at first to comprehend a falsehood, a creature of pure denotation—and matures into a master of identity-statements, of benediction, metaphor, and creed. His humanization is a passage from extension to identity, from witness to worshipper. Heinlein refuses to adjudicate. The Fair Witness survives the novel as a profession and as a person, and the unresolved coexistence of Anne's discipline and Mike's gnosis is, as Chapter Eight argues, the novel's ethical center of gravity.

2.4

A Grammar of Incorporation: The Martian Lexicon

The Martian words that survive translation constitute a compressed metaphysics. *Grok* unites in a single root the acts of drinking, understanding, loving, hating, and merging; cognition, affection, and ingestion are not three faculties but one. *Waiting is* is grammatically subjectless: no agent waits; waiting occurs. It approximates what Émile Benveniste (1950) analyzed as the middle voice, in which the subject is interior to the process it undergoes rather than its external author. *Fullness* designates the completion of a process that

cannot be hastened, and *wrongness* an aesthetic-ontological verdict of incongruity. *Water brother* grounds kinship in co-ingestion rather than descent or contract.

The most revealing coinage is *discorporate*. To die, in Martian idiom, is to leave the body—to cease being *corporate*. The word presupposes that incorporation is the default condition of existence and that death is an exit from a corpus rather than an annihilation. The lexicon therefore already contains the dissertation's thesis in miniature: to exist is to be in a body; to know is to ingest; to be kin is to have drunk together; to die is to leave one body and, as the novel's eschatology will show, to be admitted to another.

2.5

Engineered Tongues: A Comparative Typology

Martian's singularity emerges against the invented languages of the genre. Orwell's Newspeak (1949) is engineered for restriction, to render heterodoxy unthinkable; Martian is its exact inverse, engineered for expansion. A. E. van Vogt's *The World of Null-A* (1945; book 1948) made General Semantics a regimen of superhuman training; its hero belongs with Anne rather than with Mike. Samuel R. Delany's *Babel-17* (1966) imagines a weaponized language without a first-person pronoun, whose acquisition incorporates the speaker into an alien program—the dark twin of Martian, capture where Heinlein imagines communion. Ursula K. Le Guin's Pravic in *The Dispossessed* (1974), stripped of possessive constructions, attempts by morphology the abolition of property that the Nest attempts by practice. Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) imagines a semasiographic script whose mastery reorganizes temporal consciousness, so that its learner knows the future and accepts it: a secular *waiting is*, in which a mother chooses a child whose death she foresees, as the Martians accept discorporation.

The typology can be stated compactly. Newspeak restricts, Null-A disciplines, Babel-17 captures, Pravic liberates, Heptapod B reconciles. Martian alone consecrates. It is the only invented language in the canon whose grammar founds a church, and that fact is the first index of the theocorporate conversion: a language that makes its speakers one body will require an institution to hold the body together.

2.6

The First Incorporation

The plot's first incorporation precedes the narrative. A human infant was ingested by Martian culture and his nervous system colonized by a grammar; Mike is a human body inhabited by a Martian corpus. Everything that follows extends that primal act. To learn Martian is to be incorporated into Mars, and the church is the instrument by which Mars's first incorporation of a single human is extended to the species. Read in this light, the novel narrates not an alien's assimilation to Earth but Earth's assimilation, through a language, to an alien body—a reverse colonization conducted not by arms but by syntax.

PART TWO

II

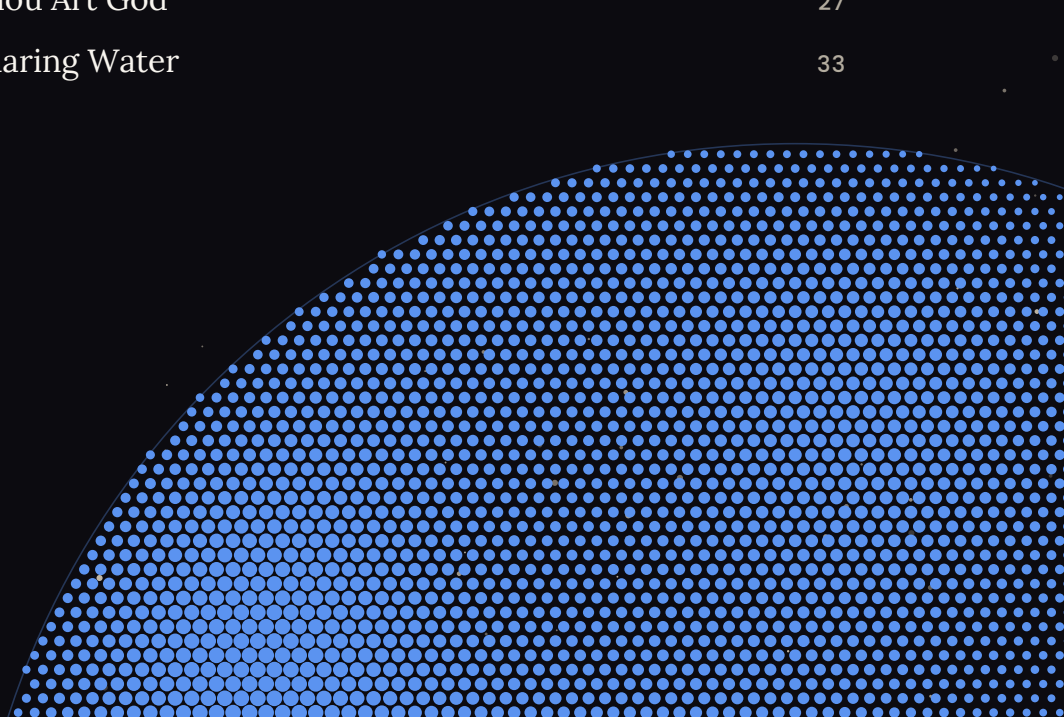
DOCTRINE

The alimentary epistemology of grok, *the second-person theology of* Thou art God, *and the hydraulic kinship and communal eros of the Nest.*

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03

TO GROK IS TO DRINK

Toward an Alimentary Epistemology

Grok is the novel's most successful export and its least understood philosopheme. Its literal sense, "to drink," is not a quaint etymology but the key to a complete theory of knowledge in which understanding is modeled on ingestion rather than on vision, grasp, or representation. This chapter reconstructs that theory, traces its sacramental pedigree, tests it against its most formidable objectors, and identifies its temporal form.

3.1

The Definition

The novel's glosses, distributed between Jubal and the semanticist Mahmoud, establish a semantic ladder. At its base *grok* means to drink; at its summit it means to understand something so completely that the knower merges with the known and loses separate identity in a shared experience. Between these poles lie loving, hating, and cherishing, for in Martian there is no cognition without affection and no affection without participation. The ladder is not metaphorical in Heinlein's usage. Martians honor their dead by eating them,

and eating is the fullest form of grokking; knowledge, love, and ingestion are phases of one act.

3.2

The Ocular Settlement

Western epistemology was founded on the eye. Aristotle opens the *Metaphysics* by observing that "all men by nature desire to know" and adducing as evidence our delight in the senses, above all sight. Plato's analogy of the sun makes the Good the source of intelligibility as the sun is the source of visibility; *theoria* derives from *theōrein*, to behold; Descartes grounds certainty in what is perceived clearly and distinctly. Hans Jonas's "The Nobility of Sight" (1954) gave the settlement its most lucid phenomenological defense: sight alone presents a simultaneous manifold, operates at a distance, and leaves its object untouched, and these features make it the model of objectivity. Richard Rorty (1979) and Martin Jay (1993) later anatomized the ocular metaphorics of modern philosophy and their twentieth-century crisis.

The Fair Witness is the ocular settlement made into law. Her knowledge is what can be seen from here, reported without contamination, and her authority depends on the distance between knower and known. She is never changed by what she witnesses. The novel's epistemic drama is the confrontation between this regime of the eye and a regime of the mouth, in which knowledge is achieved not by distance but by its abolition.

> *Truth ripens, and premature grokking is a species of error.*

3.3

The Counter-Tradition of Taste

The alimentary alternative is older than its Martian avatar. Latin *sapientia* derives from *sapere*, to taste or to have savor; Isidore of Seville derived the sage from savor, and medieval theologians glossed wisdom as *sapida scientia*, savory knowledge. The Psalmist's invitation—"O taste and see that the LORD is good" (Psalm 34:8)—places tasting before seeing. Augustine's *Confessions* (7.10.16)

records the divine voice announcing itself as the food of the mature and reversing the direction of nutrition: *nec tu me in te mutabis … sed tu mutaberis in me*—you will not change me into yourself, but you will be changed into me. This inversion is precisely the novel's definition of *grok*. Ordinary eating converts the eaten into the eater; divine eating converts the eater into the eaten; grokking is the latter made general.

Ignatius of Antioch called the Eucharist the medicine of immortality, and the Coptic *Gospel of Thomas*, recovered at Nag Hammadi and first published in 1959, contains a saying in which whoever drinks from Jesus's mouth becomes like him, while Jesus becomes that person and hidden things are revealed. The logion (108) is a Gnostic formula of reversible incorporation through drinking, and a second saying (13) describes the disciple as intoxicated from a spring the master has measured out. Whether or not Heinlein encountered these texts—the homologous register governs here—the Martian verb reactivates a sacramental epistemology in which to drink the knower is to become the known.

3.4

Philosophies of Participation

Modern philosophy preserved the alimentary alternative in secularized forms. Hegel's *Phenomenology* (1807) announces Spirit as "Ich, das Wir, und Wir, das Ich ist"—the I that is We and the We that is I—and culminates in absolute knowing as the identity of knower and known. Bergson's "Introduction to Metaphysics" (1903) defined intuition as an intellectual sympathy by which one enters an object rather than circling it. Lévy-Bruhl (1910) described a "law of participation" in which the knower shares the being of the known. Buber's *I and Thou* (1923) distinguished relation from the experience of objects, and Michael Polanyi's *Personal Knowledge* (1958) grounded tacit knowing in the knower's indwelling of particulars.

Freud supplied the primal scene. *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) traced the "oceanic feeling" of unity with the world to the infant's ego before it distinguishes itself from the maternal breast, and *Group Psychology and the Analysis of the Ego* (1921) modeled identification on the oral phase, in which a prized object is assimilated by being eaten. Grokking's primal scene is the nursling: the first drinking is the first knowing, and the first knowing is a merger. Merleau-Ponty's late ontology of the flesh ("Eye and Mind," 1961; *The*

Visible and the Invisible, 1964) described the reversibility of touching and touched but insisted that this reversibility is always imminent and never realized; a gap, an *écart*, persists. That *écart* names exactly what grokking claims to abolish, and it will return as the witness remainder.

3.5

The Levinasian Objection and Lem's Ocean

The most rigorous objection to the alimentary epistemology appeared in the novel's own year. In *Totality and Infinity* (1961) Levinas analyzed enjoyment as "living from" and nourishment as the transmutation of the other into the same; ethics begins where the face of the Other interrupts that assimilation. By Levinas's lights grokking is the ontology of the Same elevated into a sacrament. Lem's *Solaris* (1961) mounts the parallel speculative objection: the ocean cannot be drunk; the scientists who study it receive only materialized fragments of their own memories, mirrors of themselves; the protagonist's closing speculation of an imperfect, evolving god concedes that the alien is the limit of cognition, not its object.

Heinlein's implicit rejoinder is that grokking is reversible. Mike groks humanity and is converted into it; he learns laughter, jealousy, and grief, and becomes, by his own account, human. The Augustinian inversion guarantees that incorporation is mutual transubstantiation rather than conquest. Yet asymmetry returns at the point of judgment. What is grokked as wrong is not assimilated but expelled, discorporated. The alimentary epistemology has an excretory shadow: its complete cycle comprises ingestion (grokking), assimilation (fullness), and elimination (discorporation). Bakhtin's lower bodily stratum is thus inscribed in the novel's metaphysics, and the Martian elders' destruction of an entire planet, remembered as the asteroid belt, is cosmic digestion.

3.6

Waiting Is: The Temporality of Digestion

The ocular settlement is synchronic: a glance takes in a manifold at once, and the Fair Witness testifies to an instant. The alimentary epistemology is diachronic: a meal is consumed and digested over time, and grokking cannot be hurried. *Waiting is* names the temporal form of knowledge as maturation. Its

analogues are Keats's "negative capability" (1817), the capacity to remain in uncertainty without irritable reaching after fact; the Taoist *wu wei*; and Heidegger's *Gelassenheit* (1959), a releasement toward things that lets them come to presence. Heinlein's Martians, whose deliberations span centuries, embody the principle at geological scale. The novel's most original epistemological proposal is therefore not that knowledge is ingestion but that, being ingestion, it has the temporality of digestion: truth ripens, and premature grokking is a species of error.

3.7

Comparanda

Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953) imagines a gestalt being whose members constitute one cognitive organism, a Nest achieved by neurology rather than by water. Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) consummates incorporation without remainder: the last generation of children is absorbed into the cosmic Overmind, and the Earth is consumed in the process. Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) offers the empathy box, which fuses its users in the shared suffering of a stoned and climbing prophet. Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) supplies the most exact analogue: the Water of Life, a poison transformed and drunk, grants the drinker the memories of her ancestors, so that the dead are grokked by drinking. Against these incorporators stands Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969), whose Handdara cultivate a disciplined unknowing, *nusuth*, and treat the demand for total answers as a spiritual danger. Heinlein belongs with Sturgeon, Clarke, and Herbert; Le Guin and Lem stand with Levinas on the far side of the *écart*.

The chapter's result can be stated as a definition. The alimentary epistemology holds that knowledge is reversible incorporation, whose complete cycle includes the elimination of the indigestible and whose temporal form is digestion. Every institution the novel constructs will reproduce this structure.

04

THOU ART GOD

Pantheism, Autotheism, and the Grammar of the Second Person

The creed of the Church of All Worlds is three words long, and its grammar is its theology. *Thou art God* confers divinity before it claims it; it is spoken to another before it is said of oneself. This chapter reconstructs the formula's genealogy across Vedantic, biblical, patristic, antinomian, Transcendentalist, Feuerbachian, Nietzschean, and American metaphysical traditions, and argues that its second-person grammar makes it constitutively ecclesial: a divinity conferred by address requires a community of address.

4.1 The Formula

In the novel the phrase functions as greeting, benediction, and doctrine, and its extension—all that groks is God—universalizes it to every knowing being. The archaic intimate pronoun is deliberate. The creed does not say "I am God," the formula of the madman and the tyrant, but addresses the divinity of the one before the speaker; the first person follows only by reciprocity. The Upanishadic pedagogy observes the same order. In the *Chāndogya Upaniṣad* (6.8.7) Uddālaka instructs his son Śvetaketu with *tat tvam asi*, "thou art that";

only thereafter does the tradition assemble the first-person *ahaṁ brahmāsmi*, "I am Brahman" (*Bṛhadāraṇyaka* 1.4.10), among its great sayings. The second person is the door to the first.

The Vedantic formula reached American readers through Emerson and, in Heinlein's own decade in Los Angeles, through the Vedanta Society of Southern California, where Aldous Huxley, Christopher Isherwood, and Gerald Heard studied; Huxley's *The Perennial Philosophy* (1945) opens with a chapter titled "That Art Thou." No document places Heinlein in that circle, and the connection belongs to the ambient register. But the milieu in which he wrote the earliest drafts of the novel was one in which *tat tvam asi* had become the watchword of an Anglo-American perennialism.

4.2

"Ye Are Gods": The Biblical and Patristic Warrant

The creed has a scriptural warrant that the novel's death scene makes explicit. Psalm 82 has God address the members of his council: "I have said, Ye are gods," and then, "ye shall die like men." In John 10 those the Gospel calls "the Jews" (*hoi Ioudaioi*, a polemical term that many scholars read as the Judean religious leadership rather than the Jewish people as such) take up stones against Jesus because "thou, being a man, makest thyself God," and he answers by citing the Psalm: "Is it not written in your law, I said, Ye are gods?" The episode is the template of Mike's end. Universal deification is proclaimed, the charge is blasphemy, and the penalty prescribed in Leviticus 24:16 is stoning; the first Christian martyr, Stephen, is stoned by the hearers at his trial before the Sanhedrin, with Saul, the future Paul, consenting, while he sees the heavens opened (Acts 7). The Psalm's second clause is the novel's plot: the gods die like men.

> *Sight preserves the object at a distance; touch meets it at the surface; taste takes it inside.*

Eastern Christianity developed the Psalm into the doctrine of *theosis*. Athanasius's *On the Incarnation* (§54) states that God became human so that humans might become divine; the Second Epistle of Peter promises that

believers become "partakers of the divine nature" (1:4); and patristic theology located the principal means of deification in the Eucharist, in which the communicant is assimilated to the body he consumes. *Thou art God* is therefore not an anti-Christian slogan but an ultra-Christian heresy: theosis without the mediation of the Church, deification democratized. The remaining chapters show that the mediation thus abolished returns in a new institutional form.

4.3

Antinomian Lineages

The democratization of theosis has a long heretical history. The Brethren of the Free Spirit taught that the perfected soul is united with God and stands beyond moral law; Marguerite Porete, author of *The Mirror of Simple Souls*, was condemned as a relapsed heretic by the Dominican inquisitor William of Paris and burned at the stake in Paris on 1 June 1310 for describing the soul annihilated into divine union; the Ranters of the English Revolution, among them Abiezer Coppe, proclaimed God in all things and practiced a sexual antinomianism. Norman Cohn's *The Pursuit of the Millennium* (1957), published four years before the novel, portrayed the Free Spirit adepts as a self-deified elite of amoral supermen and read them as precursors of modern totalitarian movements. Cohn's portrait is the critical mirror in which the Nest must be examined: an elect that is God, that loves without property, and that kills without guilt.

William Blake gave the lineage its prophetic English voice. *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* declares that "All deities reside in the human breast," and *The Everlasting Gospel* addresses the reader in the novel's own grammar: "Thou art a Man, God is no more." Behind Blake stands Spinoza, for whom whatever is, is in God, and God is nature under another name. The antinomian tradition supplies the Nest's sexuality and the Spinozist tradition its ontology; Heinlein's originality lies in joining them to an epistemology of ingestion.

4.4

A Sensory History of American Pantheism

American pantheism can be written as a migration across the sensorium. Emerson's *Nature* (1836) records the moment in which he becomes "a

transparent eye-ball" and declares "I am part or parcel of God": deification by vision, the Over-Soul apprehended by the sense of distance. His Divinity School Address (1838), which located divinity within the soul rather than in historical revelation, cost him his welcome at Harvard for nearly three decades. Whitman's *Song of Myself* (1855) relocates the divine organ to the skin: "Divine am I inside and out," and whatever he touches or is touched by he makes holy. Deification by contact replaces deification by vision.

Heinlein completes the sequence. His pantheism is neither ocular nor tactile but alimentary: one becomes God by drinking and is finally consummated by being eaten. The trajectory from eye to skin to mouth is a progressive collapse of distance between the divinizing sense and its object. Sight preserves the object at a distance; touch meets it at the surface; taste takes it inside. Each step intensifies the incorporative logic, and the American theology of the divine self arrives, in 1961, at the sense in which subject and object cannot remain two.

4.5

The Humanist Inversion: Feuerbach, Nietzsche, and the Self-Caused Self

Ludwig Feuerbach's *The Essence of Christianity* (1841) reduced theology to anthropology and proclaimed *homo homini Deus est*, man is God to man; his *Principles of the Philosophy of the Future* (1843) located the divine in the unity of I and Thou. The novel's creed is Feuerbachian in grammar: divinity is neither in the self alone nor in a transcendent Other but in the relation of address. Nietzsche supplied the dramatic form. The madman of *The Gay Science* (1882) announces the death of God, and Zarathustra, after years of solitude, descends from his mountain to teach the overman, canonizes laughter, and demands the creation of new values. Mike descends from Mars as Zarathustra descends from the mountain, and his church is a school of value-creation in which the old tablets—monogamy, property, the fear of death—are broken.

The inversion has a solipsistic limit, which Heinlein explored before and after the novel. Twain's stranger ends by reducing the universe to a dream and the self to a solitary thought. Heinlein's "All You Zombies—" (1959), written as the novel neared completion, gives its protagonist the attribute of *causa sui*: through time travel and a change of sex the protagonist is his own mother and father. The late novels of the World as Myth sequence—*The Number of the Beast* (1980) through *To Sail Beyond the Sunset* (1987)—elaborate a "multiperson

solipsism" in which every creative consciousness is a demiurge. *Thou art God* is the ethical correction of solipsism: if I am God, so art thou. It pluralizes the self-caused self, and a plurality of gods who must acknowledge one another requires a community of acknowledgment—a church.

4.6

American Metaphysical Religion and the Occult Milieu

The ambient register is dense. American New Thought, from Phineas Quimby through Ralph Waldo Trine's *In Tune with the Infinite* (1897), Unity, and Religious Science, taught the divinity of mind and its power over matter; William James's *Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902) analyzed its "religion of healthy-mindedness." Guy Ballard's "I AM" Activity, launched by *Unveiled Mysteries* (1934), placed Ascended Masters on Mount Shasta and identified the "Mighty I AM Presence" with the God within each person. Heinlein's "Lost Legacy" (1941) had already placed a secret brotherhood of adepts on Mount Shasta who teach latent psychic powers to worthy students—the Nest's pedagogy, two decades early. Theosophy's hidden Masters, disembodied or long-lived adepts who supervise human evolution, are structural cousins of the Martian Old Ones.

Aleister Crowley's *Book of the Law* (1904) proclaimed that "Every man and every woman is a star," and his *Liber Oz* (1941) that "There is no god but man." Crowley's American lodge flourished in Pasadena in the 1940s under the rocket chemist Jack Parsons, who moved in the same Los Angeles science-fiction circles as Heinlein; L. Ron Hubbard, Heinlein's friend, joined Parsons in the Babalon Working of early 1946, a sequence of sex-magic rites meant to incarnate the goddess Babalon in a human woman, before founding Dianetics and, in 1953, incorporating Scientology. None of this establishes that Heinlein borrowed from Thelema, and the evidence is circumstantial. It establishes that the formula of human self-deification was, in his milieu, a live proposition with institutional ambitions. After 1961 the formula flowed back into the culture: Esalen was founded in 1962, Maslow's *Toward a Psychology of Being* appeared the same year, Alan Watts's *The Book* (1966) taught its readers that they were the cosmos disguised, and the Church of All Worlds adopted *Thou art God* and *Thou art Goddess* as liturgy.

4.7

Performative Divinity

J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) distinguished constative utterances, which describe, from performative ones, which enact. *Thou art God* is performative. It does not report a metaphysical fact; it consecrates the addressee and binds the speaker to cherish what has been consecrated. Buber's claim that every particular Thou affords a glimpse of the eternal Thou gives the performative its theological depth, and Émile Durkheim's *Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), which identified the god of the clan with the clan itself transfigured, gives it its sociological one. Each utterance of the creed is a micro-Durkheimian rite in which a community makes itself sacred to itself. A performative divinity requires a community of performance; a creed that exists only in mutual address cannot survive the dispersal of those who address one another.

4.8

The Thanatology of Gods

If all who grok are God, who may kill, and whom? The novel answers that discorporation is not annihilation. The self persists, among the Martian Old Ones or in the celestial offices of the coda, and the removal of a wrong body is therefore a relocation rather than a murder. The *Bhagavad Gītā* (2.19) makes the same argument to Arjuna: the Self neither slays nor is slain, and so the warrior may fight. J. Robert Oppenheimer later recalled the *Gītā*'s theophany—the god become Death, destroyer of worlds—as the thought that came to him at the first atomic test. The novel appeared in the year of the largest nuclear detonation in history and three years after Heinlein's own public campaign, through the self-styled Patrick Henry League, against the suspension of American nuclear testing. Its metaphysics of harmless killing, and its Martian elders who once destroyed a planet, belong to the nuclear imaginary.

Thou art God thus founds two things at once: a church of mutual consecration and a sovereignty of painless killing. Chapter Five follows the first into the Nest; Chapter Seven follows the second into political theology.

05

SHARING WATER

Eros, the Nest, and the Communal Body

The Nest is the novel's second body: a community of many members made one not by contract or descent but by co-ingestion and interpenetration. This chapter reconstructs its hydraulic kinship, its genealogy in the history of communal eros, its economics, and its sexual politics, and argues that the mystical body it constitutes is, from the outset, a corporation in waiting.

5.1

Hydraulic Kinship

Mars, in the tradition Heinlein inherited from Percival Lowell's *Mars* (1895) and Edgar Rice Burroughs's dying Barsoom, is a desert world on which water is the scarcest of goods. To share it is therefore the supreme bond, and water-brotherhood grounds kinship in a third principle beside blood and contract: co-ingestion. The novel's first water-sharing is almost comically mundane. Jill Boardman, a nurse, hands her guarded patient a glass of water, and in doing so contracts, without knowing it, the most solemn obligation Mike can conceive. A routine act of care is transfigured into a vow, and the plot's entire community grows from a hospital tumbler.

The biblical resonances are dense. Abraham's servant recognizes the destined bride when Rebekah draws water for him and his camels (Genesis 24); Jesus, a Jew in Samaria, asks a Samaritan woman "Give me to drink" (John 4:7) and then offers her living water; the water that becomes a spring within the drinker is the Johannine image of incorporated grace. Herbert's Fremen, four years after Heinlein, would build an entire ethics on water discipline, reclaiming the water of the dead for the tribe. In both novels, sacred hydraulics converts a scarce substance into the medium of communal property and communal identity.

5.2

The Nest as Mystical Body

The Church of All Worlds is organized in graded circles of initiation, and at its center lies the Nest: an inner community of water-brothers who live together unclothed, share sexual partners, hold property in common, pray and teach in Martian, and progressively achieve telepathic union. The Pauline template is exact: "ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular" (1 Corinthians 12:27). So is the Durkheimian one: the Nest's gatherings are occasions of collective effervescence in which the group experiences its own unity as sacred power. Hegel's Spirit, the I that is We, and Sturgeon's *homo gestalt* describe the same structure in idealist and speculative registers.

> *The mystical body became a corporation.*

Jean Starobinski's *Jean-Jacques Rousseau: La transparence et l'obstacle* (1957) supplies the most precise diagnostic term. Rousseau dreamed of a society of perfect transparency in which hearts would be immediately legible to one another, and he experienced every mediation—language, money, the veil, the mask—as an obstacle. Telepathy abolishes the obstacle. The Nest is Rousseau's transparent community realized by psychic means, and its peace, as Chapter Seven argues, depends on that transparency: members who are gods can coexist without sovereign violence only because no member can conceal anything from the others.

5.3

Genealogies of Communal Eros

The utopian tradition of shared sexuality begins with Plato's proposal of a community of spouses and children among the guardians (*Republic* V) and continues through Tommaso Campanella's *City of the Sun* (1602) and Charles Fourier's *Le Nouveau Monde amoureux*, written around 1816–18 and suppressed until 1967. Its closest historical analogue is John Humphrey Noyes's Oneida Community (1848–1881), which practiced "complex marriage," in which every man was married to every woman; regulated sexual relations by "male continence"; disciplined its members through "mutual criticism"; held all property in common; and grounded the whole in a perfectionist theology according to which the sanctified could live without sin. Oneida was a community of deified humans practicing communal eros and communal property.

Oneida's end is the decisive precedent for this dissertation's thesis. In 1881 the community dissolved its complex marriage and reorganized itself as a joint-stock company, Oneida Community, Limited, which would become famous for its silverware. The mystical body became a corporation. The trajectory the novel narrates—communal eros under a doctrine of human divinity, sustained by common property, converted into an incorporated entity that outlives its founders—had already been lived in upstate New York.

The twentieth century supplied the theory. Wilhelm Reich's *The Sexual Revolution* (1936; English 1945) argued that sexual repression produces the authoritarian character; Herbert Marcuse's *Eros and Civilization* (1955) envisioned a non-repressive sublimation that would free Eros from the performance principle; Georges Bataille's *L'Érotisme* (1957) described eroticism as the passage of discontinuous beings toward a continuity whose limit is death. Bataille's formula unites the Nest's two defining practices. Erotic union and discorporation are two roads toward continuity, and the Nest's bedroom and the Martian mortuary belong to a single metaphysics.

5.4

Against Property: Engels and the Gift

The Nest treats jealousy as a "wrongness," a failure to grok, and the novel's attack on monogamy is inseparable from its attack on property. Friedrich Engels's *Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* (1884) had argued

that monogamous marriage arose to secure the paternity of heirs to private property. The Nest abolishes both: sexual exclusivity and private money disappear together, and an unguarded common store of cash, from which members draw at need, replaces the household purse. Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) and Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) supply the economic vocabulary: the Nest runs on gift and expenditure rather than exchange and accumulation.

The contradiction is structural and unconcealed. The Nest's communism is financed by what the novel presents as one of the largest private fortunes on Earth, Mike's inheritance of patents, royalties, and the estates of the lost expedition. The gift economy is the expenditure of accumulated capital, a potlatch staged by an heir. The mystical body therefore rests upon a juridical-economic body—the estate—and cannot exist without it. The second body presupposes the third.

5.5

The Politics of the Gaze

The Nest's erotic economy is not neutral with respect to sex, and critical honesty requires saying so plainly. Jill delivers a notorious aside holding that in nine cases out of ten a woman who is raped is partly to blame, and the narrative does not contest it. Her education includes a sojourn as a Las Vegas showgirl during which she learns to enjoy being looked at by men and interprets that enjoyment as a stage of enlightenment. Laura Mulvey's account of cinematic "to-be-looked-at-ness" (1975) describes exactly the position the novel sanctifies. The community's sexuality is insistently heterosexual, organized around a male founder, and liberating chiefly in the sense of expanding sexual access.

Yet the women of the Nest are also its operative clergy. Jill, the former Fosterite Dawn Ardent, and the tattooed carnival performer Patty Paiwonski teach, recruit, and preside, and the church's spread depends upon their ministry. The Nest is a patriarchal mystical economy with female officers. The incorporative body has a sex, and its universality is qualified by that sex from the start.

5.6

Comparanda

Aldous Huxley bracketed the novel with two utopias of engineered intimacy. *Brave New World* (1932) stages a Solidarity Service in which communal worship culminates in orgy, sex as pacification and communion as social control. *Island* (1962), published the year after Heinlein's novel, imagines Pala, where *maithuna*, a yoga of love, and "mutual adoption clubs" dissolve the possessive family; Pala is destroyed by an oil-hungry neighbor as the Nest's temple is destroyed in a siege by the Fosterites. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (1924) rations sex by pink ticket; Le Guin's Anarres permits freely chosen partnership without property; Kurt Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963) offers *boko-maru*, the mingling of awareness through the soles of the feet, as a comic deflation of mystical union. Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935) gathers supernormal humans into an island colony with its own sexual ethic, which chooses self-annihilation rather than subjugation when the great powers arrive. Heinlein's own later fiction elaborates the Nest into line marriages and group families from *The Moon Is a Harsh Mistress* (1966) to *Friday* (1982).

5.7

The Corporation in Waiting

The Nest is a body of many members whose unity is achieved by ingestion and interpenetration: water, eros, telepathy. It is the novel's mystical body. But its economic substrate is an estate, its legal envelope is a church, and its historical precedent is a community that became a company. The Nest is a corporation in waiting, and the next chapter describes the corporation it becomes.

PART THREE

III

INSTITUTIONS

The corporate sacred of the Fosterites, the Church of All Worlds, and Heaven, and the political theology of sovereignty and discorporation.

06 The Church of All Worlds, Incorporated 39

07 Sovereignty, Wrongness, and Discorporation 44

06

THE CHURCH OF ALL WORLDS, INCORPORATED

Charisma, Show Business, and the Corporate Sacred

The novel contains three religious institutions—the Fosterite Church of the New Revelation, the Church of All Worlds, and Heaven—and all three are firms. This chapter argues that the triptych is not a satirical accident but a demonstration: once the sacred is democratized, the corporation is the only modern form capable of holding a body of many members together across time, and the novel's Heaven is a corporation because the corporation is Heaven secularized.

6.1

The Fosterite Economy of Salvation

The Fosterites are Heinlein's portrait of American religion as entertainment industry. Their sanctuaries accommodate drinking and games of chance; their theology promises happiness here and hereafter; their congregations are disciplined into a political bloc; and their authority descends from a dead prophet, Foster, through a Supreme Bishop, Digby, who administers the charisma he did not possess. The models are legible: Aimee Semple McPherson's theatrical Angelus Temple (1923), the mass crusades of Billy Graham, Norman Vincent Peale's *The Power of Positive Thinking* (1952), and the

neon sacrality of Las Vegas. The literary ancestors are Sinclair Lewis's *Elmer Gantry* (1927), Twain's anticlerical satire, and Herman Melville's *The Confidence-Man* (1857), whose Mississippi steamboat is a floating marketplace of faith.

Max Weber's categories specify the diagnosis. *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1904–05) traced how ascetic Protestantism read worldly success as a sign of election; the Fosterites invert the ethic, reading consumption rather than labor as the sign of grace. *Economy and Society* (1922) described the routinization of charisma after a prophet's death, and the Fosterite bureaucracy is its textbook case. William James's "religion of healthy-mindedness" (1902) supplies the psychology: the Fosterites are the once-born faith of the affluent society, a church that has never grokked pain.

6.2

The Carnival and the Conjuror

Before founding his church Mike works with Jill in a traveling carnival as a conjuror whose tricks are real miracles disguised as illusions. The episode states the novel's axiom that religion is show business and show business is religion, and it inverts the conjuror's ethic: the stage magician fakes the supernatural to sell entertainment, while Mike fakes the natural to conceal the supernatural. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) identified carnival as the social form of laughter, the grotesque body, the banquet, and the mock crowning and uncrowning of kings. Mike, the uncrowned claimant to a planet, is a carnival king, and the novel's movement from sideshow to temple is the carnivalization of sacred history. The Secretary-General's household, where the wife of the world's chief executive consults an astrologer of carnival origins, confirms the continuity from the midway to the summit of the state.

> *The angel is the first civil servant, and Weber's iron cage extends beyond the grave.*

6.3

Religion as Instrument in Heinlein's Fiction

Heinlein had rehearsed the instrumental church twice before. "If This Goes On—" (1940) imagines an American theocracy overthrown by a secret fraternal conspiracy, and *Sixth Column* (serialized 1941; book 1949) imagines a band of scientists who invent a religion, the Temple of Mota, and deploy advanced physics as miracles to resist an occupying power. The Church of All Worlds unites these precedents: it is sincere where the Temple of Mota is fraudulent, but like it, it uses the legal privileges of religion to shelter a technology of power. In the novel the church form is chosen as the most protected vehicle available to a heterodox community under American law. L. Ron Hubbard's passage from the science-fictional therapeutics of *Dianetics* (1950) to the incorporation of the Church of Scientology (1953) provides the contemporary exemplum of the same conversion, executed by a member of Heinlein's own circle.

6.4

From Corpus Mysticum to Corporation

Henri de Lubac's *Corpus Mysticum* (1944; revised 1949) showed that the term "mystical body" originally designated the Eucharistic host and migrated in the twelfth century to designate the Church, while "true body" moved in the opposite direction, from the Church to the sacrament. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957), published four years before the novel, followed the migration further: from the Church to the realm, whose king possessed a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic. F. W. Maitland's "The Corporation Sole" (1900) described the English legal device by which an office—a parson, a bishop, the Crown—becomes a perpetual person distinct from its successive holders. The genealogy runs from the altar to the Church to the state to the corporation, and at each stage a body of many members is made one person that survives its members' deaths.

Nineteenth-century jurisprudence divided over the nature of that person. Friedrich Carl von Savigny treated the juristic person as a fiction created by law; Otto von Gierke insisted that associations possess a real group personality that law merely recognizes. The novel dramatizes the dispute without resolving it. The Nest is a Gierkean real person, a group-being with a telepathic common life; the Church of All Worlds, Incorporated, is its Savignian fiction, the legal

persona that owns property, receives donations, and speaks in court. The real mystical body cannot survive without the fictive legal one, and Oneida's reorganization as a company in 1881 had already shown what the fiction does to the reality it shelters.

6.5

The Juridical Afterlife: Corporations That Pray

American law has since converged on the novel's fusion. The reporter's headnote to *Santa Clara County v. Southern Pacific Railroad* (1886) recorded the Court's view that corporations are persons under the Fourteenth Amendment; *Citizens United v. FEC* (2010) extended to corporations robust protection for political speech; and *Burwell v. Hobby Lobby Stores* (2014) held that closely held for-profit corporations may exercise religion under the Religious Freedom Restoration Act. Churches are corporations, and corporations may now be religious persons. The Fosterite bloc, meanwhile, anticipated the late twentieth-century fusion of mass evangelical organization and electoral politics. The novel's satire has become American constitutional doctrine.

06

6.6

The Fiction Incorporated

The novel's own church crossed from fiction into law. In the early 1960s Tim Zell, later Oberon Zell-Ravenheart, and Lance Christie, students at Westminster College in Fulton, Missouri, formed a water-brotherhood modeled on the book; in 1968 it was incorporated as the Church of All Worlds and began publishing *Green Egg*, adapting the creed into *Thou art God* and *Thou art Goddess*. A fictional corporation became a real one. The theocorporate conversion was executed on the novel's content by its readers, who did precisely what the novel describes: they took a mystical body constituted by shared water and gave it a charter.

6.7

Heaven, Incorporated

The novel's celestial scenes complete the triptych. Heaven is an administration in which Foster and Digby hold archangelic rank, receive assignments, and discuss personnel; Mike, discorporated, is revealed as the archangel Michael,

adjusts his halo, and sets to work. The satire belongs to the Menippean tradition of heavenly councils: Seneca's *Apocolocyntosis* (c. 54 CE) mocks the deification of Claudius by staging the gods' debate as a Senate session; Lucian sends Menippus to eavesdrop on Olympus; James Branch Cabell's *Jurgen* (1919) discovers a Heaven constructed to the specifications of a grandmother's belief, and Heinlein's own *Job*: A *Comedy of Justice* (1984) would return to the Cabellian cosmos. Emanuel Swedenborg's *Heaven and Hell* (1758) supplies the sincere version: angels live in organized societies and perform "uses," useful occupations, forever. His *Earths in the Universe* (1758) even describes the spirits of Mars as among the most celestial, conversing through an inward, nearly silent speech and the expression of the face.

Giorgio Agamben's *The Kingdom and the Glory* (2007) gives the heavenly bureaucracy its genealogy. Agamben argues that the theological paradigm of divine *oikonomia*, the providential government of the world, was the matrix of modern administrative power, and that angelology, with its ministers, ranks, and missions, is the prototype of bureaucracy. Heinlein's Heaven literalizes the thesis: the angel is the first civil servant, and Weber's iron cage extends beyond the grave. The triptych now stands complete. The Fosterite church is a commercial firm, the Church of All Worlds a communal firm, and Heaven a cosmic firm. The chapter's result is the dissertation's law, the *theocorporate conversion*: every democratization of the sacred terminates in its incorporation and administration.

07

SOVEREIGNTY, WRONGNESS, AND DISCORPORATION

The Political Theology of the Man from Mars

The Man from Mars arrives on Earth as a legal problem before he becomes a religious one, and the novel's political theology is the story of how his sovereignty is dissolved: first alienated from his person by contract, then distributed among his disciples by grammar, and finally absorbed into the offices of Heaven. Along the way the novel confronts, and refuses to condemn, the question of who may be killed.

7.1

The Larkin Decision and the Colonial Void

The novel's speculative jurisprudence turns on the Larkin Decision, a fictional precedent arising from lunar claims under which title to an extraterrestrial body might vest in its human occupant. Mike, the only human born and raised on Mars, is therefore a potential sovereign of a planet. The doctrine descends from John Locke's account of property as the mixing of labor with unowned nature (*Second Treatise*, 1689) and from the colonial fiction of *terra nullius*. Its satirical edge is precise. Mars is inhabited by an ancient civilization, yet under the doctrine the Martians are legally invisible; the only occupancy human law can see is human occupancy. Heinlein reproduces, on a planetary scale, the

jurisprudence by which inhabited continents were declared empty. Jubal's settlement then undoes the erasure: Mike keeps his fortune but gives up sovereignty, and the Martians are recognized as the planet's true proprietors.

The question has since left fiction. The Outer Space Treaty (1967) forbade national appropriation of celestial bodies "by means of use or occupation"; the Moon Agreement (1979) failed to win the major spacefaring powers; the United States' Commercial Space Launch Competitiveness Act (2015) recognized private property in extracted space resources; and the Artemis Accords (2020) elaborated a regime of operational "safety zones." The Larkin question has returned as a question of resources rather than territory. The novel adds a reversal that the colonial archive rarely contemplates. Mars sends its creature back: the claimant to Mars is Mars's instrument, and the empire of Earth is colonized by a grammar. The Empire writes back, to borrow the title of Ashcroft, Griffiths, and Tiffin's study (1989), and here it writes in Martian.

7.2

Two Bodies and a Power of Attorney

Kantorowicz's distinction between the king's body natural and body politic describes Mike's predicament exactly. His body natural is a frail, Martian-trained organism held under guard in a hospital; his body politic is a bundle of claims—to a planet, to patents, to estates, to celebrity as "the Man from Mars"—that makes him the object of the World Federation's covetousness. Jubal Harshaw's jurisprudence consists in separating the two. By the settlement under which the Secretary-General becomes the administrator of Mike's affairs by power of attorney, the predator is converted into a fiduciary; the body politic is alienated in order to protect the body natural. The presence of a Fair Witness at the negotiation authenticates the transaction. Jubal is, fittingly, lawyer, physician, and author: the custodian of the political body, the natural body, and the fictions through which a mystical body will later be imagined.

> *In an incorporative polity the enemy is not an adversary to be defeated or a criminal to be tried but indigestible matter to be expelled.*

7.3

The Decision on Wrongness

Mike kills. He discorporates the armed squad sent to seize him at Jubal's house, assailants who threaten him or his brothers, the Fosterite Supreme Bishop Digby, and others. In each case the act follows a grokking of "wrongness," an aesthetic-ontological verdict reached by incorporation of the other's being. The knower is the judge; no norm stands above the verdict; no procedure intervenes between perception and execution.

Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) defined the sovereign as he who decides on the exception and argued that the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts. Mike's grokking fuses cognition and decision in a form Schmitt never imagined: an epistemic sovereignty in which the decision is not willed but known. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) identified the figure of bare life, which may be killed without the killing counting as homicide. The discorporated are killed without murder, because their selves are held to persist and their wrongness to be known. The narrative's equanimity before these deaths is the novel's moral scandal, and no reading that ignores it deserves assent.

7.4

The Elect and the Competent

Starship Troopers (1959), written in the interval of the novel's composition, grounds the franchise in voluntary federal service and treats violence as the ultimate source of political authority. Criticism has often treated the two books as antitheses, militarist and libertine. They are better read as esoteric twins. Both ground authority in demonstrated capacity: the veteran's vote and the adept's miracles are two aristocracies of competence, and both novels reserve lethal judgment to those who have proven their fitness. Slusser's Calvinist elect, Cohn's self-deified supermen, and Nietzsche's master morality converge on the Nest. Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935) and A. E. van Vogt's *Slan* (serialized 1940) supply the genre's earlier portraits of a persecuted superhuman elect.

Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Hard to Be a God* (1964) supplies the Soviet counter-image. Its protagonist, an Earth historian living incognito on a medieval planet, possesses godlike powers and is bound by a doctrine of non-intervention; when the woman he loves is killed, he breaks the doctrine in a massacre that the novel presents as catastrophe and moral collapse. The

Strugatskys' god must not act, and his action is horror. Heinlein's god acts serenely, and the narrative calls his action love. The comparison measures exactly what the incorporative theology must suppress in order to remain a gospel.

7.5

Mortmain: The Old Ones and the Dead Hand

Mars is governed by its dead. The Old Ones, discorporate Martians, deliberate over centuries, and their verdicts bind the living. English law named the corresponding institution *mortmain*, the dead hand, and the Statute of Mortmain (1279) restrained perpetual landholding by religious corporations precisely because a corporation that never dies accumulates without limit. The Old Ones are mortmain as polity: an ancestral sovereignty of the incorporated dead. Theosophy's hidden Masters and C. S. Lewis's Oyarsa, the angelic intelligence that governs an unfallen Mars in *Out of the Silent Planet* (1938), are their closest literary and occult analogues; Lewis's Earth is the "silent planet," cut off by the bent angel who rules it, as Heinlein's Earth is a world under Martian review.

The Old Ones once grokked a planet as wrong and destroyed it, and its remains are the asteroid belt, a fictional realization of Heinrich Olbers's hypothesis (1802) that the asteroids are fragments of a disrupted planet. Earth may be next, and Mike's mission acquires an eschatological deadline: to teach humanity to grok before the elders complete their deliberation. H. G. Wells had given Mars "intellects vast and cool and unsympathetic" that coveted the Earth (1898); Heinlein replaces envy with aesthetic judgment. Arthur C. Clarke's Overlords in *Childhood's End* (1953) and Klaatu in *The Day the Earth Stood Still* (1951)—an alien messenger who takes the alias "Mr. Carpenter," is killed and revived, and warns that incorruptible robotic enforcers will destroy a violent humanity—belong to the same postwar genre of planetary judgment. The genre is the Doomsday Clock (1947) transposed into myth, and 1961, the year of the largest nuclear test in history, was the year in which humanity acquired the power the Old Ones exercise.

7.6

A Polity of Gods

If every Thou is God, every adept is sovereign, and the Nest's members do acquire powers of discorporation. A polity of sovereigns is, in Hobbesian terms, a state of nature: a war of each against each, since every member holds the power of death. The Nest escapes that condition only through total transparency. Its members cannot conceal intentions from one another, and Rousseau's dream of a community without obstacles, realized by telepathy, replaces the Leviathan. The Nest is peaceful because it is transparent, and transparent because it is one body.

Sovereignty, in the novel, is thus not abolished but dissolved into incorporation. What can be incorporated is loved, taught, and married; what cannot be incorporated is discorporated. In an incorporative polity the enemy is not an adversary to be defeated or a criminal to be tried but indigestible matter to be expelled. This is the political form of the alimentary epistemology's excretory shadow, and it is the price the novel pays for its love.

PART FOUR

IV

ENDS

The fall into laughter and the ethics of finitude, and the theophagy that founds the body.

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08

THE FALL INTO LAUGHTER

Pain, the Fallen Caryatid, and the Ethics of Finitude

The incorporative theology has a limit, and the novel knows it. Three things resist ingestion: the pain that laughter acknowledges, the finitude that art dignifies, and the testimony that refuses to exceed its evidence. This chapter argues that these constitute a *witness remainder*, that the novel locates its custodian in Jubal Harshaw, and that Mike's humanization depends not on grokking but on a fall.

8.1

The Monkey House

The turning point of Mike's education occurs at a zoo. Watching the monkey house, he sees a large monkey beat a smaller one and seize its food, and the victim, rather than retaliate against its tormentor, beat a still smaller monkey. Violence cascades down a hierarchy, each humiliation passed to the next weaker body. Mike laughs for the first time, uncontrollably, and afterward explains that he now groks people: humans laugh because it hurts, and laughter is the way a suffering species keeps from being destroyed by its pain. He describes himself, after this, as having become human.

The scene is the hinge of the novel's anthropology. Before it Mike possesses Martian perfection—bodily mastery, telepathic perception, lethal judgment—but lacks the one capacity the novel treats as distinctively human. After it he can found a church. The founder of the religion of incorporation is qualified for his office by an experience of what cannot be incorporated: another's pain, received as one's own and answered with laughter.

8.2

Theories of Laughter

The classical theories illuminate the scene from different sides. Hobbes's "sudden glory" (*Leviathan*, 1651) makes laughter the triumph of superiority, and the monkeys enact superiority as a chain. Kant (*Critique of Judgment*, 1790, §54) derives laughter from a strained expectation suddenly reduced to nothing; Bergson's *Le Rire* (1900) from the mechanical encrusted upon the living, and the cascade of blows is exactly a mechanism operating through living bodies. Freud's *Jokes and Their Relation to the Unconscious* (1905) treats laughter as an economy of psychic expenditure, and his essay "Humour" (1927) describes humor as the ego's rebellious refusal to be overwhelmed by reality's provocations. Mike's laughter is Freudian humor in its purest form: pain recognized and refused dominion.

> *The novel's final ethical figure is not the angel adjusting his halo but the old man who eats and weeps.*

Charles Baudelaire's "De l'essence du rire" (1855) supplies the theological key. "Le rire est satanique, il est donc profondément humain": laughter is satanic and therefore profoundly human. For Baudelaire laughter is born of the Fall; the Sage does not laugh, or laughs only with trembling; unfallen beings have no occasion for it. Mike, raised among unfallen Martians, cannot laugh until he groks the Fall, and his laughter is his fall into humanity. It is, however, a *felix culpa*, a fortunate fall, because it opens compassion: to grok pain is to share its water. Twain's stranger had called laughter humanity's one effective weapon; Nietzsche's Zarathustra canonized it; Bakhtin made it the regenerative

principle of carnival; William James would say that at the monkey house Mike becomes twice-born. The Fosterites, whose theology of happiness has never grokked pain, remain once-born.

8.3

The Fallen Caryatid

The novel's aesthetic credo is delivered by Jubal before a work of Auguste Rodin. Jubal explains to Ben Caxton why the *Fallen Caryatid Carrying Her Stone*, conceived around 1881 for *The Gates of Hell*, moves him more than any triumphant figure: the caryatid, a woman whose body serves as an architectural column, has collapsed under her burden and yet continues to hold it. The sculpture's subject is courage as persistence in failure. Jubal's companion enthusiasm for Rodin's *She Who Was Once the Helmet-Maker's Beautiful Wife*, after François Villon's lament of the aged courtesan, extends the credo to the ruined body: beauty survives decay and is even disclosed by it. Jubal's populist aesthetics, in which art is defined by its capacity to communicate an emotion to an ordinary viewer, is less important than the emblem it selects.

The caryatid is architecture's human support, the finite body on which an edifice rests. Fallen, she does not merge with the stone or dissolve into the building; she bears. She is the precise antithesis of grokking. Where grokking abolishes the distance between the knower and the known, the caryatid maintains the distance between the bearer and the borne; where discorporation releases the self from its burden, the caryatid keeps hers. Albert Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942), which asks us to imagine Sisyphus happy, belongs to the same ethic. The fallen caryatid is the novel's image of what the incorporative system can neither digest nor do without.

8.4

Jubal the Cainite

The name is a program. In Genesis 4:21 Jubal, of the line of Cain, is "the father of all such as handle the harp and organ," and his brothers Jabal and Tubal-cain found pastoralism and metallurgy, while Cain himself builds the first city. The arts, the crafts, and the city descend from the first murderer. Jubal Harshaw—lawyer, physician, prolific author of popular fiction, patriarch of a self-governing household in the Poconos—is the Cainite artist: the civilized,

fallen, and productive human whose culture is built on a primal violence and redeemed by making. Beside him Mike is an Adamic figure from an unfallen world. The novel's pairing of the two is the pairing of Eden with the city.

The novel's onomastics repay the same attention. The journalist Ben Caxton bears the name of William Caxton, England's first printer, and embodies the press as public witness. Valentine Michael Smith unites love, the archangel, and the most common of English surnames. The Fosterite church, named for its founder, is also a *foster* church, and its rival is founded by a fostered child, a human raised by alien parents. Names, in this novel, are small creeds.

8.5

The Witness Remainder

Anne the Fair Witness is the novel's other saint. Her discipline is a refusal to incorporate beyond evidence: she testifies to what she has seen and to nothing else, and her authority depends on remaining unchanged by what she witnesses. As Jubal's household is drawn toward the Nest, the Witness function travels with it; the novel never abolishes it and never subordinates it. Merleau-Ponty's *écart*, the gap that keeps reversibility from closing, and Levinas's asymmetry, which keeps the Other from being assimilated, name the same persistence in philosophical terms.

The witness remainder can now be defined. It is that which the incorporative system requires and cannot metabolize, and it has three forms: testimony, knowledge that preserves distance; laughter, knowledge that preserves pain; and finitude, being that preserves its burden. Jubal is its custodian. He remains a skeptic while becoming a patron of the church; he grieves when Mike dies; he tries to kill himself with an overdose and is saved by Mike's apparition; he joins the funeral meal and remains himself. The novel's final ethical figure is not the angel adjusting his halo but the old man who eats and weeps.

09

THEOPHAGY

The Funeral Feast and the Founding of the Body

The novel's climax joins the two most ancient scandals of religion, the collective murder of the holy one and the eating of his body, and presents both as fulfillments rather than crimes. This chapter reads the stoning and the funeral meal through comparative religion, psychoanalysis, and cannibal metaphysics, and argues that theophagy is the hinge on which the three bodies of Valentine Michael Smith turn.

9.1

The Stoning

When the Fosterites have besieged and destroyed the temple and the Nest has taken refuge, Mike goes out alone to face a mob that the Fosterites have raised against him, speaks to it, and is stoned and beaten to death while the police stand by. The biblical templates are explicit. In John 10 those the Gospel calls "the Jews" take up stones because a man "makest thyself God," and the answer is the Psalm's universal deification; in Acts 7 Stephen is stoned by the crowd at his Sanhedrin hearing, Saul consenting, while he sees the heavens opened; Leviticus 24:16 prescribes stoning for blasphemy. Kipling's Mowgli, driven from the village under stones, supplies the feral child's version of the same fate.

René Girard's theory of the founding murder (*Violence and the Sacred*, 1972; *Things Hidden since the Foundation of the World*, 1978) describes the structure precisely: a community in mimetic crisis converges unanimously upon a single victim, and the victim, once killed, is sacralized as the source of the order his death restored. Heinlein literalizes the sacralization—the victim becomes an archangel—but reverses the moral that Girard draws from the Gospels. For Girard the Passion reveals the victim's innocence and thereby discredits sacrificial religion; in Heinlein the victim consents, choreographs his death, and his community neither repents nor mourns in the ordinary sense. It eats. Henri Hubert and Marcel Mauss (1899) defined sacrifice as communication between sacred and profane through a consecrated victim; Mike is sacrificer and victim at once, the priest who offers himself.

9.2

The Broth

Martian custom honors the dead by eating them, since eating is the fullest form of grokking. The Nest, in fidelity to that custom, eats Mike's body, prepared as a broth: ritual cannibalism, which the novel presents as sacrament. Jubal partakes. After the murder he had tried to kill himself with an overdose of pills and was saved only when Mike, appearing to him after death, made him bring them up. The scene is the novel's most scandalous and its most logically necessary. It repeats the scandal of the synagogue at Capernaum, where Jesus declares "Except ye eat the flesh of the Son of man" and "many of his disciples went back" (John 6:53, 66); the novel's readers, who have accepted free love and summary execution, have often balked here, and their revulsion reenacts the defection. The meal is transubstantiation in reverse. In the Mass bread becomes flesh while retaining the appearance of bread; in the Nest flesh becomes food while retaining the identity of flesh.

> *The Martian totem meal is Freud's primal scene without repression.*

James George Frazer's chapter "Eating the God" in *The Golden Bough* (3rd ed., 1906–15) assembled the comparative evidence, including the Aztec rite in which

a dough image of Huitzilopochtli was broken and consumed under the name *teoqualo*, "god is eaten." William Robertson Smith's *Lectures on the Religion of the Semites* (1889) derived sacrifice from a communal meal in which the clan ate its god. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) built on Robertson Smith a myth of origins: the band of brothers kills and devours the primal father, and the totem meal, repeated in guilt, founds religion, morality, and social order.

The water-brothers are Freud's brothers redeemed. The father consents to his death, the meal is joyous, and guilt is replaced by grokking. The Martian totem meal is Freud's primal scene without repression, and its product is not a law of prohibition but a church of incorporation. What Freud imagined as the traumatic origin of all religion, Heinlein imagines as the happy completion of one.

9.3

Mourning without Crypt

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguished the work of mourning, which gradually detaches the libido from the lost object, from melancholia, in which the ego identifies with the lost object and the shadow of the object falls upon the ego. Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok (1972) refined the distinction into a contrast between *introjection*, the gradual assimilation of the loss into an enlarged ego, and *incorporation*, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole and harboring it intact within a psychic "crypt." Jacques Derrida's "Fors" (1976) meditated on that crypt as a sealed interior that resists every reading.

The Martian funeral collapses the distinction that psychoanalysis holds essential. Literal incorporation performs the work of introjection: the Nest swallows its founder and is thereby enlarged, not encrypted. The secret crypt is replaced by the public church, the unreadable interior by a sacrament. In a late interview, "Eating Well" (1989), Derrida argued that since every relation to the other involves some form of assimilation, the question is not whether to eat but how to eat well. The Nest's answer is the novel's: eat only what consents to be eaten, eat in fullness, and let the eaten grok the eaters as they grok him.

9.4

Cannibal Metaphysics

Montaigne's "Of Cannibals" (1580) used the Tupinambá to estrange European cruelty, judging the cannibal who eats the dead less barbarous than the Christian who tortures the living. Oswald de Andrade's "Manifesto Antropófago" (1928), with its motto "Tupi or not tupi," made cultural devouring the method of Brazilian modernism: the colonized swallows the colonizer's culture and transforms it. Eduardo Viveiros de Castro's ethnography of the Araweté (1986; English as *From the Enemy's Point of View*, 1992) and his *Cannibal Metaphysics* (2009) supply the most exact structural parallel. Among the Araweté the killer incorporates the perspective of his slain enemy, whose voice sings through him, and the celestial gods devour the souls of the dead before remaking them as immortal divinities.

To eat, in Amerindian perspectivism, is to take a point of view; to be eaten by the gods is to become one. This is grokking stated as ethnography, and the novel's eschatology—eaten by his brothers, promoted to an archangel—is Araweté in structure. The homology owes nothing to influence, and that is its value: it shows that Heinlein's apparently lurid climax reconstructs, from speculative premises, a coherent metaphysics that human societies have actually lived.

9.5

The Heavenly Coda

The eaten god is promoted. In the celestial scenes Mike, revealed as the archangel Michael, adjusts his halo and sets to work, and the last movement of the novel is toward labor. The Protestant vocation, Weber's *Beruf*, is eternalized: even beatitude is a job. The Kantorowiczian formula is now complete. The body natural has been eaten; the body mystical, the Nest, disperses to found new temples; the body corporate, the Church on Earth and the office in Heaven, persists. Theophagy is the hinge. By it the natural body is ingested by the mystical body, which survives as corporate body in two jurisdictions, terrestrial and celestial.

9.6

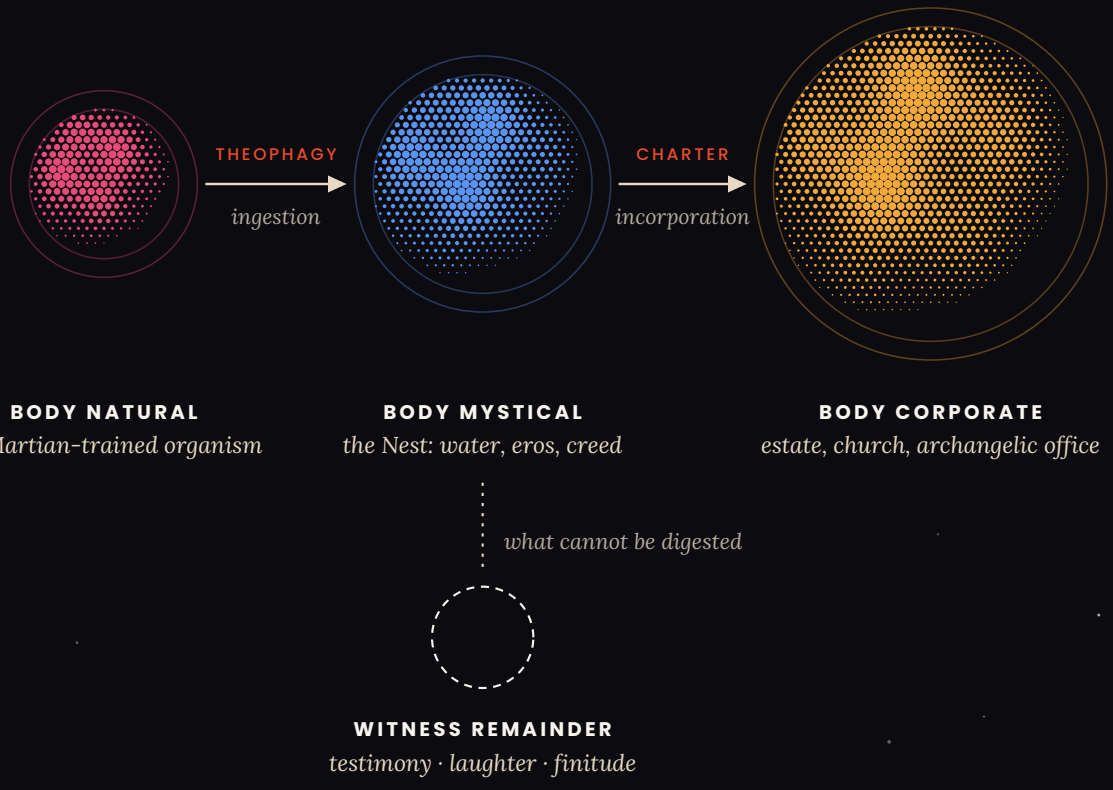
The Anthropophagic Text

The novel's method mirrors its climax. It devours its sources—Kipling and Twain, Cabell and Korzybski, Frazer and the King James Bible, the Upanishads and the occult lodges of Pasadena—and returns them transformed, as Andrade's anthropophagy prescribes. It was designed, moreover, to be ingested rather than merely read: a book of creeds, coinages, and rituals that readers could take into their mouths and their lives. Its reception, from the Church of All Worlds to the hacker lexicon, is its final chapter. *Stranger in a Strange Land* is a Eucharistic text, and it has been received as one.

SYNTHESIS

THE THEOCORPORATE CONVERSION

Figure 1. The three bodies of Valentine Michael Smith, and the remainder none of them can digest (Chapter Ten, §§10.1–10.2).



"*Every democratization of the sacred terminates in its incorporation and administration.*"

THE LAW OF THE THEOCORPORATE CONVERSION · §10.1

SYNTHESIS

10

CORPUS MARTIANUM

The Theocorporate Conversion

The preceding chapters have followed incorporation through language, knowledge, divinity, eros, institution, sovereignty, laughter, and death. This chapter assembles the results into a theory: it states incorporative pantheism as a sequence of propositions, derives the law of theocorporate conversion and its corollaries, reconstructs the three bodies of the protagonist, shows that the novel's contradictions are consequences of the theory, identifies the genre proper to it, places the novel in a typology of incorporative fictions, advances a historical claim about its afterlife, and proposes an ethic.

10.1 Incorporative Pantheism Stated

The theology the novel articulates can be stated in six propositions. First (P1), to know is to incorporate: understanding is a mode of ingestion, as the Martian root of *grok* declares. Second (P2), complete incorporation is reversible identity: the knower is converted into the known as much as the known into the knower, according to the Augustinian inversion that the novel's gloss of *grok* reproduces. Third (P3), whatever groks the whole is the whole; hence *Thou*

art God and its extension to all that groks. Fourth (P4), mutual incorporation among many knowers constitutes one body of many members, the water-brotherhood and the Nest. Fifth (P5), a body of many members that must hold property, survive the deaths of its members, and act in law requires a juridical person, the corporation. Sixth (P6), therefore democratized divinity is realized as a corporation: the Church of All Worlds on Earth and the celestial administration in Heaven.

From these propositions follows the law this dissertation names the *theocorporate conversion*: every democratization of the sacred terminates in its incorporation and administration, so that the more widely divinity is distributed, the more elaborately it must be managed. Three corollaries follow. The first (C1) is that the indigestible is expelled: an incorporative community cannot tolerate what it cannot assimilate, and it discorporates "wrongness." The second (C2) is that the incorporated sacred requires officers, and its hierarchy culminates in an angelic civil service. The third (C3) is that the system generates a remainder it can neither metabolize nor survive without: testimony, laughter, and finitude, the witness remainder.

> *The more widely divinity is distributed, the more elaborately it must be managed.*

10.2

The Three Bodies of Valentine Michael Smith

Kantorowicz's medieval king possessed two bodies because the mystical and the political had not yet been separated; the *corpus mysticum* of the Church had lent its concept to the realm. In modernity the two have divorced, and the stranger therefore requires three. His *body natural* is the Martian-trained organism, capable of metabolic self-regulation, trance, and voluntary death. His *body mystical* is the Nest, constituted by water, eros, telepathy, and creed. His *body corporate* is the bundle of claims, estates, and offices that attach to him: the claimant to Mars, the heir to patents and royalties, the incorporated church, and finally the archangelic office.

The plot transfers the person from the first body to the third through the second. In the hospital Mike is only a body natural, guarded and medicalized. Jubal's jurisprudence detaches the body corporate from the body natural in order to protect the latter. The founding of the Nest constitutes the body mystical. Theophagy is the hinge: the natural body is ingested by the mystical body, which then persists as a corporate body in two jurisdictions. The novel's work is to reunite what modernity divorced, and the only bonding agent available to it is the corporation.

10.3

Contradictions as Consequences

The four contradictions that have organized criticism are now derivable from the theory. The coexistence of free love and summary execution follows from C1: incorporation and expulsion are two phases of one digestive process, and a community that loves by ingestion must eliminate what it cannot digest. The passage from anti-institutional mysticism to incorporation follows from P5 and P6: a mystical body that must endure requires a legal one. The juxtaposition of radical immanence with a bureaucratic Heaven follows from C2: the democratized sacred must be administered, and administration is its eternal form. The coexistence of Jubal's skepticism with his discipleship follows from C3: the system requires a custodian of what it cannot absorb.

The novel's reception reproduces the structure. The counterculture received the mystical body, propositions P1 through P4, and read the book as a gospel of communion; the libertarian and satirical readings received the corporate body, P5, P6, and C2, and read it as an anatomy of institutions. Each saw half of the conversion. The aesthetic-failure thesis saw both halves and mistook their juncture for a seam, when it was in fact a hinge.

10.4

The Menippean Gospel

A creed whose logic terminates in administration must satirize its own apotheosis in order to remain a creed, for a gospel that ended by solemnly enthroning a bureaucracy would refute itself. The form proper to incorporative pantheism is therefore a *Menippean gospel*: a scripture that contains its own satire. Bakhtin's account of Menippean satire (1929; revised 1963)—its

experimental fantasy, its threshold dialogues, its scenes in Heaven and among the dead, its mixture of the sacred and the scandalous—fits the novel's heavenly scenes exactly. The part titles, from "His Maculate Origin" to "His Happy Destiny," parody the saint's life, and the doubled voice of Mike and Jubal, the preacher and the anatomist, distributes gospel and satire between two persons who love each other. The Menippean restoration of Patterson and Thornton identified the genre; the present theory explains its necessity.

10.5

A Typology of Incorporative Fictions

The novel's place in the speculative canon can be fixed on two axes: the fiction's attitude toward the incorporation of the Other, whether embraced or resisted, and its stance toward the sacred that results, whether sincere or ironic. Sincere fictions of embraced incorporation include Clarke's *Childhood's End*, whose Overmind absorbs humanity; Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937), whose cosmic spirit is assembled from communal minds; and Sturgeon's *More Than Human*, whose gestalt learns an ethic proper to itself. Ironic fictions of embraced incorporation include Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle*, whose Bokononism is a religion of consciously useful untruths; Dick's *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch* (1965), whose chewed drugs Can-D and Chew-Z admit their consumers to shared and finally predatory worlds; and Heinlein's own *Sixth Column*.

Sincere fictions of resisted incorporation include Lem's *Solaris*, Le Guin's Handdara, James Blish's A *Case of Conscience* (1958), whose Jesuit confronts an unfallen alien race without God, and Walter M. Miller Jr.'s A *Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959), which defends institutional tradition against apocalyptic merger. Critical fictions of resisted incorporation include Herbert's *Dune* cycle, in which messianic incorporation issues in galactic jihad; the Strugatskys' *Hard to Be a God*; and Huxley's *Brave New World*. *Stranger in a Strange Land* alone occupies both sincere and ironic positions on the side of embrace. It believes in incorporation and anatomizes its administrative destiny in the same breath, and this double position is its singularity in the canon. Chiang's "Story of Your Life" offers a later, post-incorporative resolution in which knowledge is accepted without merger: understanding that transforms the knower while leaving the known intact.

10.6

The Historical Claim: From Nest to Network

Fred Turner's *From Counterculture to Cyberculture* (2006) showed how the communalist wing of the counterculture, through Stewart Brand's *Whole Earth Catalog* (1968) and its successors, supplied the ideals and networks of digital utopianism and, eventually, of networked corporate culture; Richard Barbrook and Andy Cameron named the resulting synthesis "the Californian Ideology" (1995). The trajectory from Esalen to Silicon Valley is the theocorporate conversion executed as social history: communal mysticism converted into corporate techno-culture, the mystical body of the commune reincorporated as the firm. *Grok* was the password of the passage, carried from the novel into the commune and from the commune into the hacker's lexicon. The novel is the founding fiction of that passage, not because it caused it but because it narrated its logic in advance.

10.7

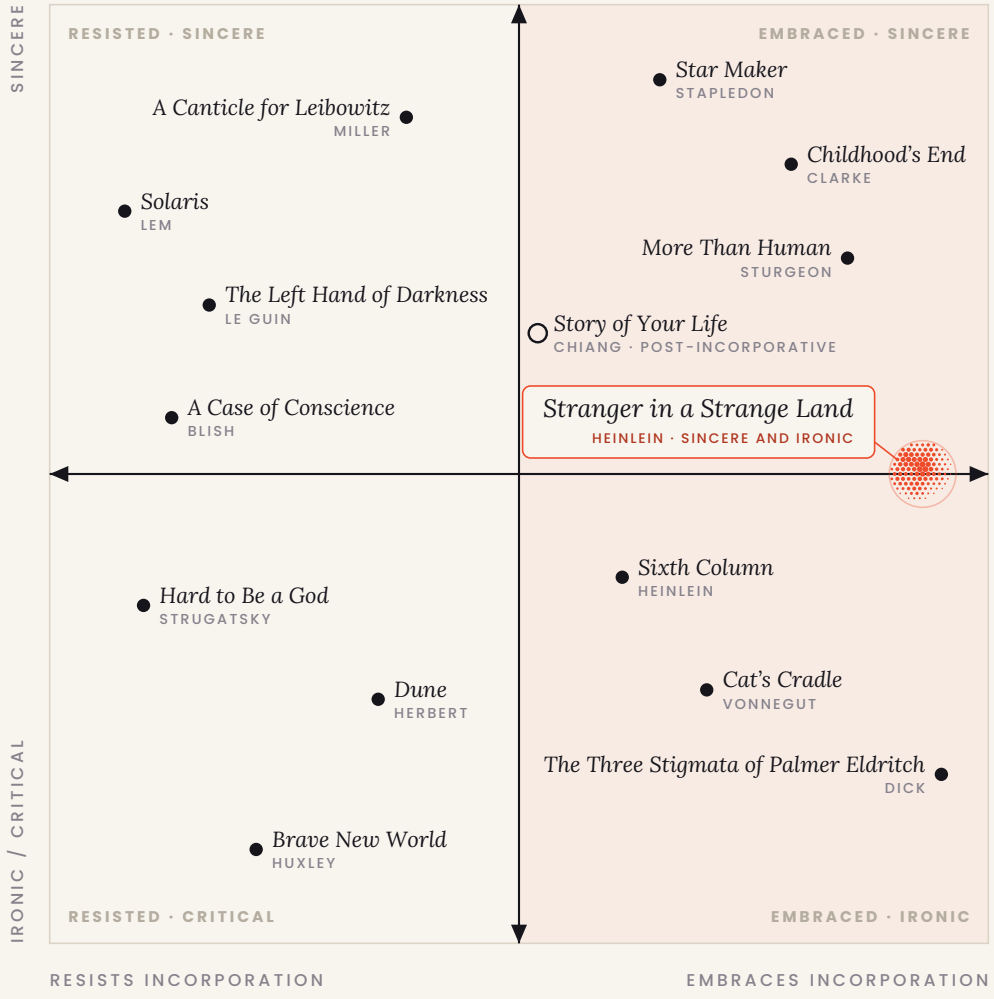
An Ethic of Eating Well

A theory of the novel yields, finally, a normative proposal. If knowledge in a networked age increasingly takes the form of incorporation—of data ingested, communities merged, identities absorbed into platforms—then the novel's unresolved dialectic between Mike and Anne becomes a practical question. The ethic it suggests may be called *incorporation with remainder*. Grok, but keep a Fair Witness: let every act of merging be accompanied by testimony that refuses to exceed its evidence. Let *waiting is* govern the tempo of understanding, so that incorporation is never premature. Laugh, so that pain is acknowledged rather than digested. Bear, as the caryatid bears, what cannot be dissolved. The novel's deepest wisdom lies not in the Nest and not in Heaven but in the unfinished negotiation between the grokker and the witness, adjudicated by an old Cainite who eats and weeps.

FIGURE 2

A Typology of Incorporative Fictions

The two axes of Chapter Ten, §10.5: a fiction's attitude toward the incorporation of the Other (horizontal) and its stance toward the sacred that results (vertical). Stranger in a Strange Land alone straddles sincerity and irony on the side of embrace. Placements are interpretive.





GROKKING AFTER THE CORPUS

The novel's central verb has outlived its context three times, and each migration has carried it further along the path the theocorporate conversion predicts: from a sacrament to a professional ideal, from a professional ideal to an empirical phenomenon, and from an empirical phenomenon to a corporate trademark.

The Hacker's Sacrament

The Jargon File, begun at Stanford in 1975 and later published as *The New Hacker's Dictionary* (1991), adopted *grok* as the highest term of praise for technical understanding: to grok a system is to know it from the inside, so thoroughly that one thinks in its terms. The phrase "grok in fullness" passed into the same lexicon. The word thereby shed its theology and retained its epistemology. The hacker who groks a codebase has not become God, but he has been converted into the system he understands, and the professional culture that prized this conversion was itself a descendant of the communalist counterculture Turner describes. *Grok* entered the *Oxford English Dictionary* with the novel as its first citation, completing its naturalization.

II

Grokking as an Empirical Phenomenon

In 2022 Alethea Power, Yuri Burda, Harri Edwards, Igor Babuschkin, and Vedant Misra reported that small transformer networks trained on algorithmic tasks, such as tables of modular arithmetic, reach perfect accuracy on their training examples early while performing at chance on held-out examples; then, after training continues far beyond the point of apparent overfitting, and with the help of regularization such as weight decay, performance on unseen examples abruptly rises to near perfection. They named the phenomenon *grokking*. Neel Nanda and colleagues (2023) reverse-engineered a network that had grokked modular addition and found that it had learned an algorithm based on discrete Fourier transforms and trigonometric identities; they also showed that the apparently sudden transition was prepared by gradual, measurable changes in the network's internal structure, a phase of circuit formation followed by a phase of cleanup.

> *The sacred word of a church founded on the eating of its god is now a commercial trademark for a system built by ingestion.*

The phenomenon reenacts the novel's epistemic dialectic with uncanny fidelity. The memorization phase is the Fair Witness phase: the network testifies to what it has seen, instance by instance, indexed and exact, and to nothing beyond. The generalization phase is the grokking phase: the network incorporates the rule that generated its examples and is thereby converted into a structure isomorphic to the domain. The interval between them is *waiting is*, and Nanda's finding that the sudden fullness is prepared by invisible gradual change is a precise gloss on the Martian conviction that ripeness cannot be hurried but is always underway. The Fair Witness principle itself requires a caution here. The correspondence is structural, and to claim that such networks understand in the novel's sense would be to exceed the evidence.

III

The Corpus

Large language models are trained upon a *corpus*, a body of texts ingested in order to produce a single voice composed of many voices. The Latin noun that joined the Eucharistic host, the Church, and the legal person in Chapter Six now names the archive from which such systems are made. The corpus is composed in large part of the words of the dead, and the systems it produces are, in a structural sense the novel would recognize, discorporate intelligences assembled from ancestral speech—kin, however distant, to the Old Ones, who govern Mars as a deliberative body of the incorporated departed. The analogy should not be pressed into prophecy. It shows only that the novel's vocabulary of bodies, ingestion, and ancestral judgment has become an unexpectedly exact vocabulary for describing a technology it did not foresee.

IV

The Trademark

In November 2023 xAI, a company co-founded that year by Elon Musk with a team that included Igor Babuschkin, a co-author of the 2022 paper that named the phenomenon, released a conversational model called Grok. The circuit closes. The Martian verb for incorporative knowing, having passed through the commune and the hacker's lexicon and having become the technical name of a learning phenomenon, became the brand of a corporation's machine that incorporates the human corpus. No more literal instance of the theocorporate conversion could be designed: the sacred word of a church founded on the eating of its god is now a commercial trademark for a system built by ingestion. In the same decade the engineer Anthony Levandowski, formerly of Google's and Uber's self-driving programs, registered a church devoted to a prospective artificial godhead, Way of the Future, and later dissolved it. The movement from *Thou art God* to an incorporated religion of machine divinity took less than sixty years.

V

A Fair Witness for Machine Understanding

The ethic proposed in Chapter Ten applies with special force to this afterlife. Systems that learn by incorporation should be accompanied by practices of

testimony that refuse to exceed their evidence: claims about what such systems know, and about what they are, should be indexed and dated as Korzybski demanded. The tempo of their integration into human institutions should be governed by *waiting is*. And the witness remainder—testimony, laughter, finitude—should be preserved as the part of human understanding that no corpus absorbs. Heinlein's stranger was understood in the only way his creed allowed: he was drunk. The question his novel leaves to an age of machines that grok is whether understanding can take the form of incorporation without abolishing the witness.

CONCLUSION

This dissertation has argued that *Stranger in a Strange Land* is unified by a single operation, incorporation, and that the novel's apparent incoherence is the coherence of a theology followed to its end. Its contributions can be summarized as eight claims.

First, *grok* articulates an alimentary epistemology in which knowledge is reversible incorporation, with an excretory shadow in discorporation and a temporal form in digestion; this epistemology has a sacramental pedigree running from the Psalms and Augustine through the *Gospel of Thomas* and the Eucharist. Second, *Thou art God* is a second-person creed, Upanishadic in pedagogy, Feuerbachian in grammar, and patristic in its ancestry in *theosis*, whose performative character makes it constitutively ecclesial. Third, the novel articulates *incorporative pantheism*, whose governing law, the *theocorporate conversion*, holds that every democratization of the sacred terminates in its incorporation and administration; the Fosterite church, the Church of All Worlds, and Heaven are three firms, and Oneida's reorganization as a company in 1881 and the Church of All Worlds' incorporation in 1968 show the law operating in history. Fourth, the protagonist has three bodies—natural,

mystical, and corporate—and the funeral theophagy is the hinge by which the first is ingested by the second and perpetuated as the third.

Fifth, the incorporative system generates a *witness remainder*—testimony, laughter, and finitude—embodied by the Fair Witness, by Mike's fall into laughter, and by Rodin's *Fallen Caryatid*, and kept by Jubal Harshaw, the Cainite artist. Sixth, American pantheism migrates across the sensorium from Emerson's eye through Whitman's touch to Heinlein's mouth, each step collapsing the distance between the divinizing sense and its object. Seventh, 1961 was an *annus mirabilis* of alterity in which *Solaris* and *Totality and Infinity* defended the Other's resistance to assimilation while Heinlein's novel proposed that the Other be drunk. Eighth, the novel is a *Menippean gospel*, a form made necessary by a creed that must satirize its own apotheosis to remain credible.

The study has limits. Its reliance on paraphrase, imposed by the novel's copyright status, forgoes the close stylistic analysis that quotation would permit. The variants between the 1961 and 1991 texts deserve systematic collation, especially in the sexual and theological passages the original edition cut. The Robert A. and Virginia Heinlein papers held at the University of California, Santa Cruz, may confirm or complicate the ambient genealogies proposed here, particularly the Vedantic and Thelemic ones. The study's comparative frame is predominantly Anglophone and European; a fuller account would set the novel beside Soviet, Latin American, and East Asian speculative traditions of collective consciousness and communal religion. Finally, the liturgical history of the Church of All Worlds, and the contested record of the novel's use by charismatic communes, above all the claim that the group whose members committed the Manson murders of August 1969 took the Nest as its model, merit archival treatment that a theoretical study cannot provide.

The argument's final claim is also its first. A novel about a stranger who drinks the world in order to understand it, and who is at last eaten by those he taught, has been drunk and eaten by its readers, by its culture, and now by its machines. Heinlein asked what it would mean to understand something so completely that one becomes it. His novel answers that such understanding is love, and also that it is administration, and that between the two lies an old man who bears what cannot be absorbed. The task the novel leaves its readers is to learn to drink without dissolving and to be drunk without disappearing: to grok, and still to bear witness.

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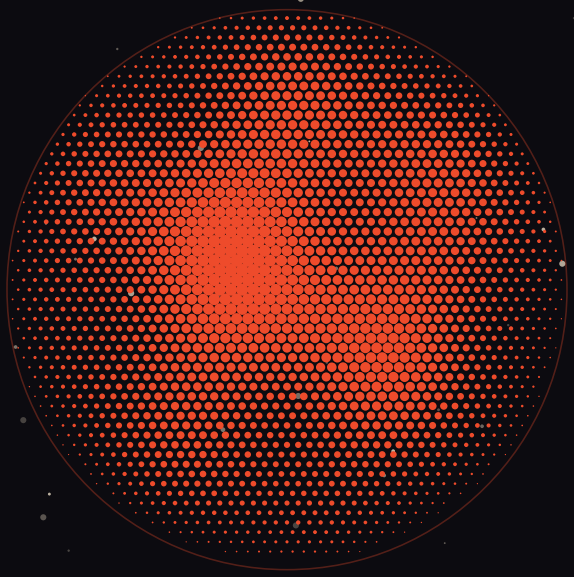
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KEYWORDS

ROBERT A. HEINLEIN / *Stranger in a Strange Land* / GROK / INCORPORATION / INCORPORATIVE PANTHEISM / THEOCORPORATE CONVERSION / THEOPHAGY / EUCHARIST / *corpus mysticum* / THE KING'S TWO BODIES / POLITICAL THEOLOGY / SOVEREIGNTY AND THE EXCEPTION / CORPORATE PERSONHOOD / GENERAL SEMANTICS / LINGUISTIC RELATIVITY / INVENTED LANGUAGES / ALIMENTARY EPISTEMOLOGY / OCULARCENTRISM / FAIR WITNESS / *Thou art God* / *tat tvam asi* / THEOSIS / PANTHEISM / AUTOTHEISM / AMERICAN TRANSCENDENTALISM / NEW THOUGHT / THELEMA / GNOSTICISM / THE ALIEN GOD / COGNITIVE ESTRANGEMENT / *ostranenie* / THE NOVUM / the *ingénu* / FERAL CHILD / MENIPPEAN SATIRE / CARNIVALESQUE / LAUGHTER AND THE FALL / WATER-BROTHERHOOD / COMMUNAL EROS / ONEIDA COMMUNITY / GIFT ECONOMY / THE MALE GAZE / DISCORPORATION / HOMO SACER / MORTMAIN / NUCLEAR IMAGINARY / CANNIBAL METAPHYSICS / AMERINDIAN PERSPECTIVISM / MOURNING, INTROJECTION, AND INCORPORATION / SCAPEGOAT MECHANISM / ALTERITY / *annus mirabilis* 1961 / SCIENCE FICTION AND RELIGION / CHURCH OF ALL WORLDS / COUNTERCULTURE / CALIFORNIAN IDEOLOGY / HACKER CULTURE / MACHINE LEARNING / GROKKING (NEURAL NETWORKS) / TRAINING CORPUS / THE WITNESS REMAINDER

Set in Lora and Poppins. On each chapter opening the planet turns a little further toward the light: a backlit crescent at the Introduction, full at the Bibliography.



WAITING IS.

Corpus Martianum